Aquifer Open Study Notes

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

John

John 1:1

In the beginning: Using the same phrase as the beginning of the Old Testament (Genesis 1:1), the Gospel of John introduces Jesus Christ as the one through whom God created everything (John 1:3). Through Jesus, God also creates new life in those who believe (1:12–13).

The Gospel of John begins with its central claim: Jesus Christ, the Word (logos), not only revealed God but was God. The Greek word logos means "word" or "message." The logos is the Word of God, through whom God created everything, made himself known, and became human as Jesus Christ. Later Christian teaching describes the Word as the second person of the Trinity (the one who shares fully in God's nature with the Father and the Holy Spirit).

In Greek thought, the logos was the rational principle that ordered the universe and made life understandable. It explained why the world had meaning and structure.

For Jewish people, the logos was the word of the Lord. It expressed God's wisdom and God's creative power. God spoke, and things came into being.

By the time of Jesus, people understood the logos as coming from God and sharing God's character and authority (see Psalm 33:6, 9; Proverbs 8:22–31). John affirmed this understanding by declaring that "the Word [logos] became flesh and made His dwelling among us" (John 1:14).

John 1:1–18

The start of this introduction might be a poem or hymn sung by early Christians (1:1–5).

The themes of this introduction of the Gospel of John prepare readers for the story that follows:

- The arrival of the light in the world.
- The rejection of the light.
- The gift of new life given by the light to those who believed in him.

John 1:3

The Word (logos) is God (1:1–2). Everything God does, the Word also does. Throughout his Gospel, John presents the actions of Jesus as the actions of God himself.

John 1:4

- In Him was life: Life was God's original gift to his creatures at creation (Genesis 1:20–28; 2:7). Now the logos gives people the possibility of new life, which comes through rebirth from God (John 1:13). This means receiving new life from God, not a second physical birth. It describes a spiritual beginning in which God gives people new life through faith, making them his children
- As one of his first creative acts, God brought light into the world (Genesis 1:3). In the re-creation of humankind through Jesus Christ, God offered light and life again. Light is a key theme throughout the Gospel of John.

John 1:4–5

God created light and removed the darkness (Genesis 1:2–5). The darkness resists God (John 3:19–21; 12:35; Matthew 6:23; Acts 26:17–18; Ephesians 4:17–19; 5:7–14; 2 Peter 1:19; 1 John 1:5–7; 2:9–11).

John 1:5

the darkness has not overcome it: Or the darkness has not understood it; literally, the darkness cannot grasp it. The Greek word katalambanō ("grasp") can mean either "understand" or "be hostile." In John's Gospel, it means "hostility." The darkness would try to destroy Jesus (the Light), but it would fail. The Light would successfully bring salvation to the world.

John 1:6–9

God sent a man named John the Baptist to announce the arrival of Jesus. He prepared people to accept Jesus as God's Son and Messiah (see 1:19–37; Luke 1:5–25, 57–80; 3:1–22). His work fulfilled what God had promised through the prophets (see Isaiah 40:3; Malachi 4:5–6).

John 1:8

Some Jews thought John the Baptist might be the Messiah (God's chosen one). Some of his followers hesitated to follow Jesus (3:22–30). However, John the Baptist was not the Light. His role was to announce Jesus (1:19–34).

John 1:10

The world does not recognize the true light, even when meeting its Creator. The world lives in rebellion, loving darkness more than light (3:19).

John 1:12

- People can follow the light and join God's family only when God spiritually renews them (3:1–17).
- People must believe in Christ to become children of God (12:35–36).

John 1:13

born of God: People can escape the darkness only by God's grace (see 8:12; 12:35–36, 44–46).

John 1:14

- The Word became flesh: This means the Word became truly human. The idea that the Word became human was shocking to both Greeks and Jews.

Many Greeks believed that God was completely separate from the ordinary human world. They used the word sarx (Greek for "flesh") to describe human life as weak or earthly. John taught something very different. He said that God himself became human in Jesus Christ (compare 1:1).
Jesus was fully human and fully divine. He was not partly God and partly human. These two truths together form the foundation of Christian teaching about Christ.

- the Word ... made His dwelling among us (Greek skēnoō, "pitched a tent"): The Greek verb skēnoō means "to pitch a tent" or "to live in a tent." This word is related to skēnē, the Greek word for the tabernacle. The tabernacle was the tent where the Lord's glory lived among Israel in the wilderness (Exodus 25:8–9). In Jesus, God's glory now lived among his people in a new way (Exodus 40:34–38; John 2:11; 12:23–28, 41; 17:1–5).
- Even though the world was dark and hostile, Jesus came to save it. He offered God's love and faithfulness to the world (3:15–17).

John 1:15

He was before me: In John the Baptist's culture, older age was respected and honored (Leviticus 19:32). Younger people were expected to honor those who were older, not replace them (contrast Isaiah 3:5).

By saying that Jesus existed before him, John the Baptist pointed to the greater honor of Jesus. He explained that Jesus existed before creation itself, not just before the birth of John (John 1:1–3).

John 1:17

- the law: This refers to the Torah, the body of instruction given to Moses at Mount Sinai. The Torah taught Israel how to live in faithful relationship with God and with one another.
- God's grace and truth are present in the Torah, but Jesus fully reveals these qualities in his person and power (3:16; 13:1).

John 1:18

- God would not allow Moses to see him directly (Exodus 33:18–20). Only Jesus has seen the Father, so he alone completely knows him and can tell us about him (John 3:32–35; 14:9–10).
- but the one and only Son: The Son, who sees the Father, is himself God. The Son is not simply a messenger who knows something about God. John explicitly affirms Christ's deity. Jesus shares the substance of God's being.

John 1:19–51

John's Gospel focuses less on John the Baptist compared to the Synoptic Gospels (Matthew 3:1–6; Mark 1:2–6; Luke 1:1–24, 57–80; 3:1–13). However, the apostle John wants us to understand that John the Baptist correctly identified and honored Jesus.

John the Baptist's disciples leave him to follow Jesus. Jesus continued the work that John had begun. As the ministry of Jesus grew, John's ministry became smaller, just as John had said (John 3:30).

John 1:19–12.50

Jesus reveals himself to the world through his miracles and teachings. People reacted differently:

- Some wanted to believe in him.
- Others opposed him.

This division becomes more obvious as the book continues. Jesus ended his public ministry with a final call for people to believe in him (12:44–50).

John 1:20

The Jews expected the Christ (the Greek form of the Hebrew word Messiah) to bring spiritual leadership and political redemption to Israel. Both words mean "Anointed One" (a king chosen and set apart by God). They believed this promised leader would guide them back to faithful worship and free them from foreign rule (see Deuteronomy 18:15; see also the Jewish book Psalms of Solomon from the period between the Old and New Testaments).

John 1:21

- The people expected Elijah to come before the Messiah (Malachi 4:5). John the Baptist fulfilled this role

as the forerunner (the one who prepares the way). However, John said that he was not Elijah himself (see Matthew 11:14; Luke 1:17).
- Are you the Prophet?: Compare John 6:14; 7:40–41.

John 1:22–23

Who are you?: John the Baptist wanted others to know him as a voice of one calling in the wilderness (see Isaiah 40:3).

John 1:24

The Pharisees were deeply devoted to the Scriptures and earnestly desired a righteous life. They also believed in the coming Messiah, which explains their questions here.

Some Pharisees became followers of Jesus, including the apostle Paul (Acts 15:5; 26:5; Philippians 3:5).

John 1:25–26

- Jewish baptisms were ritual washings for becoming ceremonially pure following contact with impurity (Leviticus 8:6; Numbers 19:7).
- John announced the Christ's arrival and required participants to confess their sins and be baptized (Matthew 3:6). Baptism later became the symbol of membership in the kingdom of God (Acts 2:38; see also John 4:1–2).

John 1:27

A slave usually did simple tasks like removing a sandal. A disciple never did these tasks.

John 1:29

The phrase the Lamb of God may refer to the Passover sacrifice of a lamb or to the daily sacrifice in the temple (Exodus 29:38–46; Hebrews 10). See also Revelation 5.

John 1:32

- John the Baptist's second testimony (see 1:19–23) describes what happened when he baptized Jesus .
- In the Old Testament, kings and prophets were anointed with the Holy Spirit. These anointings were temporary. They were given for a specific task or time.

By contrast, the Spirit remained on Jesus. His anointing was not temporary. It was permanent (see 3:34).

John 1:34

the Son of God: Some ancient manuscripts read "the Chosen One of God," which echoes Isaiah 42:1, where God speaks of his chosen servant.

John 1:35–51

This section introduces the model for discipleship in John's Gospel. Disciples wanted to come and see Jesus, and when they met him, they stayed with him (1:39).

John 1:40–42

Simon is well known in the Gospels, not for his courage and faith, but for his failings (see 18:15–18, 25–27). Jesus gave him the name Cephas, an Aramaic word that means "rock." In Greek, this name is Petros. In English, we say Peter. This name pointed to the strong church leader Simon would later become (see Acts 1:1–5:42; 8:1–12:25; 15:1–41).

John 1:43–44

- Galilee was the region of northern Israel around the Sea of Galilee.
- Bethsaida was a village on Galilee's north shore. The name Bethsaida means "house of fishing." It was the home of Peter, Andrew, and Philip. Later, Andrew and Peter moved to Capernaum, a village west of Bethsaida (Mark 1:21, 29).

John 1:45

- Philip, a Greek name, and Nathanael, a Hebrew name, represent the mix of cultures in Galilee. The message of Jesus reached both groups in Galilee. When Greeks wanted to see Jesus in Jerusalem, they asked Philip (12:20–22).
- Jesus grew up in Nazareth, a mountain village southwest of the Sea of Galilee.

John 1:46

Can anything good come from Nazareth?: People did not think this village was important enough to be the hometown of a great leader (see Matthew 13:53–58).

John 1:47

Jesus described Nathanael as a true Israelite. He said there was no deceit (no dishonesty or trickery) in him.

This may contrast Nathanael with Jacob, whose early life was marked by deceit. Jacob later received the name Israel (see Genesis 25:27–34; 27:1–36; 32:22–32). In this way, Nathanael shows what God desires Israel to

be. God wants his people to be an honest and faithful people.

John 1:48–49

Jesus gained Nathanael's attention by showing that he knew his character (1:47). Then Jesus showed that he knew Nathanael's earlier actions, even though they had not met before.

This supernatural knowledge (knowledge beyond normal human ability) amazed Nathanael. He saw this as a sign from God and responded with faith.

Nathanael had witnessed a miracle. As a result, he made a strong confession about who Jesus is.

John 1:51

- Truly, truly (Greek amēn amēn): Jesus often used this phrase to emphasize important points. In John's Gospel, the Greek word amēn is always doubled.
- you will all see heaven open: Jesus made the comparison with Jacob clear (see study note on 1:47; see Genesis 28:10–22). Like Jacob, Nathanael would see God at work. Jacob saw a vision at Bethel, where God revealed himself (Genesis 28:19).

Jesus himself is the new Bethel. The name Bethel means "house of God." In other words, Jesus is the place where God now lives among his people.

- Son of Man: See study note on John 9:35; see also Daniel 7:13–14; Mark 8:31.
- John the apostle used several names for Jesus (Son of God, Son of Man, Christ). Knowing the true identity of Jesus is necessary to fully understanding and following him.

John 2:1

Wedding ceremonies could last up to a week. They often included dramatic parades where the husband brought the bride to his home for the celebrations (Matthew 25:1–13).

John 2:1–25

In this section, Jesus appeared at two symbolic Jewish ceremonies. At a wedding in Cana (2:1–12), he replaced the ritual cleansing water with his own superior wine. Later, around Passover, he cleansed the temple (2:13–25).

John 2:1–10.42

Jesus showed who he is and what he came to do through the religious practices and festivals of the Jewish people (see 2:1; 5:1). He used these familiar events to reveal his identity and his mission.

John 2:3

- When the wine supply ran out, the host's family would face embarrassment for failure to plan properly. Perhaps Jesus arrived unexpectedly with his disciples (see Matthew 25:1–13). This might explain why his mother told him about the problem.
- A wedding feast was a major celebration in Jewish village life. This particular event also symbolized the joy of the Messiah's arrival.

John 2:4

- At first, Jesus did not step in to solve the problem. His mission and its timing were not controlled by human plans.
- My hour has not yet come: This refers to the time when Jesus would be glorified. In the Gospel of John, this happened when he was lifted up on the cross (12:23; 17:1).

John 2:6

The stone water jars were cut from solid rock. They were used for Jewish purification ceremonies (religious washing rituals; see Mark 7:1–4).

Jesus was about to give new meaning to these ceremonies. He would show that something greater than ritual washing was now present.

John 2:9–10

The master of the banquet repeated a common saying. Normally, the best wine was served first, when people could taste it most clearly. Later, wine of lower quality was served.

But this time it was different. The wine Jesus made, served last, was the best of all.

In the Old Testament, good wine was a sign of God's blessing(Amos 9:13–14). This miracle showed that the Messiah, God's greatest blessing, had now come.

John 2:11

Jesus performed this, the first of His signs: In it, he revealed the glory of God (see also 1:14; 11:4, 40).

John 2:13

The Jewish Passover was an annual spring feast remembering Israel's rescue from slavery in Egypt (Exodus 12). Jews traveled to Jerusalem to join the feast (Deuteronomy 16:1–16). Because John refers to three Passover feasts (John 2:13; 6:4; 11:55), many scholars think Jesus must have had a three-year public ministry.

John 2:14–17

- Many people came to Jerusalem for the Passover festival. They needed animals that met the requirements for sacrifice. The animals had to be approved for worship.

Because of this need, a large business developed. People sold animals and exchanged money for the right kind of coins. However, this buying and selling was taking place in the temple itself.
Jesus acted like a prophet. He demanded that God's house return to its true purpose. The temple was meant for worship, prayer, teaching, and sacrifice. It was not meant to be a marketplace. This action brought Jesus into conflict with the temple leaders.

- The Synoptic Gospels (Matthew, Mark, and Luke) place the clearing out of the temple near the end of the ministry of Jesus (Matthew 21:12–13; Mark 11:15–17; Luke 19:45–46). John might have included this event earlier to emphasize its connection to the miracle where Jesus turned water into wine (John 2:1–11). Both the temple and the stone jars of water were instruments for spiritual purity in Judaism. The jars, once filled with water for ceremonial washing, now held the wine Jesus changed by a miracle.

In a similar way, the stone temple, which was linked to sacrifice and purification, would no longer be central. Jesus himself would take its place (2:19–21).
Some scholars believe that Jesus cleansed the temple twice. They think he did this once at the beginning of his ministry and again at the end.

John 2:19–21

Destroy this temple: Herod the Great started rebuilding the temple's grand structure in 20 BC. The work continued until AD 64. This is why Jesus amazed his audience when he claimed he could destroy and rebuild it in a few days.

However, Jesus was speaking figuratively (using a word picture) about his own body. He described his body as the true temple, the place where God was present (see 1:14, 51).

His body would be destroyed. Three days later, God would raise him from the dead. Through his resurrection, Jesus showed that he himself was now the true place where people meet God. Because of this, the Jerusalem Temple and its sacrifices were no longer necessary.

Later, during the trial of Jesus, some people misunderstood his words. They used his statement about destroying the temple as evidence against him. They accused him of blasphemy (Mark 14:58).

John 2:22

they believed: Seeing a miracle from God can lead people to believe. However, this kind of belief is not the deepest faith. The deepest faith trusts Jesus even without seeing miracles (20:29).

John 2:24

John uses a play on words here. Because of Jesus's signs (miracles that show who he is), many people trusted in him (2:23). But Jesus did not trust them in the same way.

This statement does not refer only to certain people in Jerusalem. It shows that Jesus knows what is inside every person. He understands people's thoughts, motives (reasons for acting), and desires.

John 3:1

- John connects 2:25 and 3:1 by using the same Greek word (anthrōpos) to refer to all of humanity and then to a specific man (Nicodemus).
- Nicodemus had deep religious knowledge. He had also seen what Jesus was doing in Jerusalem (2:13–24). But he had not yet experienced spiritual rebirth (a new life that comes from God).
- A Pharisee: See study note on 1:24. The Pharisees were a Jewish group who were careful to obey the law of Moses and their religious traditions.

Nicodemus belonged to this group. He was part of the religious leaders. He was respected for his knowledge of the Jewish law. He likely took pride in his careful obedience and moral purity.

John 3:2

at night: Nicodemus might have been afraid for others to see him with Jesus. In the Gospel of John, night often has a deeper meaning. It can represent evil, error (wrong belief), and unbelief (lack of trust in God; see 9:4; 11:10; 13:30).

John 3:3

- Born again: To experience spiritual birth, God's power must completely renew a person.
- Nicodemus thought Jesus was speaking about physical birth. He demonstrated that those in darkness, who do not have spiritual rebirth, cannot understand Jesus or other "heavenly things" (3:12).

Jesus sometimes used ironic misunderstanding as a way to teach. He would say something with a deeper spiritual meaning. The listener would misunderstand his words in a simple or physical way. Then Jesus would explain the deeper meaning.

This method helped people see the difference between earthly thinking and spiritual truth.

John 3:5

John the Baptist baptized with water. Jesus baptizes with the Holy Spirit (1:33).

John 3:8

In Greek, the word for wind is the same as for spirit (Greek pneuma). The wind is an appropriate image for the Spirit, who is sent from heaven and cannot be contained or controlled.

John 3:13

There is a great distance between this world and heaven (see 1:51; 3:31; 6:38, 42). Heaven represents God's dwelling place. This world represents human life under sin and weakness.

Jesus came down from heaven to this world. He made a way for people to know God. He proved that he came from God when he defeated death. After rising from the dead, he returned to the Father in heaven (16:5–11).

John 3:14–15

Jesus was lifted up on the cross so that all people could understand the way of salvation, look to him in faith, and have eternal life.

John 3:16

- The truth that God loved the world is basic to Christian understanding (1 John 4:9–10). God's love extends beyond the limits of race and nation, even to those who oppose him (see "The World" Theme Note).
- The Son came to save, not to condemn, people who often choose spiritual darkness (3:17, 19–21).

John 3:16–21

The original Greek text does not include quotation marks. Because of this, translators must decide where the words of Jesus end and where John's explanation begins. John 3:16–21 might be John's explanation of what Jesus said.

John 3:18

As light shines into a dark place, it reveals what was hidden. In the same way, when Jesus came into the world, he exposed its sin and unbelief. Because of this, God's judgment has already begun.

People who see this light and understand their true condition must respond. They are responsible to believe in God's Son (3:16–17).

John 3:19–20

When people live in spiritual darkness (a life separated from God), they do not want the light that Jesus brings. Jesus called himself "the light of the world" (8:12; 9:5). His light shows truth and exposes sin.

Darkness does not simply ignore the light. It resists it and tries to overcome it. But the darkness cannot defeat the light (1:5).

Those who refuse to believe continue to live in darkness (13:30). They stumble because they cannot see clearly (11:10). In the end, their sins will be revealed. God will judge all people (5:28–30; Revelation 20:11–15).

John 3:22

He spent some time with them and baptized: See John 4:2, which explains that the disciples of Jesus were the ones who baptized people.

John 3:22–36

John the Baptist says Jesus is truly "from above" (3:31). So, the followers of John need to start following Jesus instead.

John 3:24

Before King Herod imprisoned John (see Matthew 14:1–12; Mark 1:14; 6:14–29; Luke 3:19–20), he and Jesus were both ministering near the Jordan River. They were working in the same general area.

After John was arrested, Jesus left that region. He traveled north to Galilee and began his ministry there (Mark 1:14).

John 3:26

everyone is going to Him: Many people were going to Jesus. His growing popularity made some of John's followers jealous.

John 3:27–35

John the Baptist spoke because of two concerns:

1. Some people questioned whether his baptism was from God (see 1:26), and
2. his disciples were worried because many people were beginning to follow Jesus instead of John (3:26).

John 3:29

John the Baptist described Jesus as the bridegroom. He described himself as the bridegroom's friend.

John did not try to bring honor to himself. Instead, he gave honor to Jesus and showed that Jesus is greater than he is.

John 3:31

Jesus came from heaven. Because of this, he alone was able to make the Father known (1:18; 3:13).

John 3:34–35

God gives the Spirit without limit: The Father shows his deep love for the Son (3:35). This also shows the divine nature of Jesus. John presents the one God as three persons (compare 1 John 5:5–12).

John 3:36

- God gives the gift of eternal life. This life is not only about the future. It begins now. It is a new life and a close relationship with God in the present.
- Whoever rejects the Son will not see life: The world, living in darkness and sin, already stands under God's judgment (Romans 1–3). This judgment shows God's anger against sin and evil.

John 4:1–42

- At an ancient well in Samaria, Jesus offered himself as living water. This living water means the life that comes from God. Jesus spoke openly about who he was. When he revealed God's truth, people had to respond. They either followed him or turned away.
- The Samaritan woman is very different from Nicodemus. She was a woman, not a man. She was a Samaritan, not a Jew. She had a sinful past, not a reputation for righteousness. She was an outsider, not a respected teacher of Israel.

Nicodemus came to Jesus at night and did not openly respond to the challenges from Jesus (3:1–21). The Samaritan woman spoke with Jesus in the daylight. She recognized him as Lord. She remained in the light and showed signs of becoming a disciple (see 1:35–51).

John 4:2

Jesus himself did not baptize anyone with water. He allowed his disciples to perform water baptism.

Later, after he was lifted up on the cross and then raised from the dead, Jesus returned to the Father. This suffering, death, resurrection, and return to the Father is called his glorification (7:37–39). After this, Jesus baptized people in the Holy Spirit (1:33; Acts 2:4).

John 4:3

After John the Baptist had been imprisoned, Jesus left Judea (see Mark 6:14–29; compare Mark 1:14).

John 4:4–6

- When traveling north to Galilee, Jesus chose the less common route through Samaria. Samaria and Judea had a long history of racial tension (see 2 Kings 17:24–41; Ezra 4:1–5; Nehemiah 4; 6:1–19). In the time of Jesus, there was intense racial and cultural conflict between Jews and Samaritans. Jews usually avoided Samaria by first going east to Jericho and then traveling north through the Jordan Valley.
- Sychar was likely in the area of Shechem. Jesus arrived at Jacob's well. Jacob had owned land near Shechem (Genesis 33:18–19).

John 4:7

Due to the heat, it was customary for the women to draw water in early morning or evening. However, this woman lived in isolation, separated from her community. Jesus was compassionate toward outcasts.

John 4:9

The woman was surprised. Social taboos (strict cultural rules about proper behavior) would normally prevent a Jewish teacher like Jesus from speaking to her (4:18). But Jesus did not allow these social rules to control him. He chose to speak with her and offer what she truly needed.

John 4:10

Shechem had no rivers. So it had no living water, which usually means fresh, flowing water from a stream or spring (see "Living Water" Theme Note). However, Jesus was speaking symbolically. The gift he offered was not ordinary water. It was the Holy Spirit, whom God would give to believers (7:37–39).

John 4:11

Jacob's well was more than 30 meters (about 100 feet) deep. A person needed a long rope and a container to draw water from it.

The woman focused on the physical water in the well. She did not yet understand the deeper meaning of what Jesus was saying. At that time, she was still in spiritual darkness.

John 4:12

Our father Jacob: The Samaritan woman respected the holy traditions related to the well more than the presence of God in front of her.

John 4:14

In the dry climate of Israel, a fresh, bubbling spring was a strong and hopeful image. Flowing water meant life, safety, and relief from thirst.

The prophets used this image to describe God's care. They said that those who come to God will not hunger or thirst (see Isaiah 49:10; 55:1–3; Jeremiah 2:13).

John 4:15

The woman asked Jesus for this water, but she did not understand the spiritual meaning of his words. To overcome this spiritual barrier, Jesus spoke about her sin (4:16–18).

John 4:16–18

The woman's immoral life affected her understanding. Her pattern of broken relationships kept her from seeing clearly.

She had been married five times. She was also living with a man who was not her husband. These facts show that her life did not match God's will. Her sin created a barrier between her and a full understanding of what Jesus was saying.

John 4:19

- a prophet: Jesus revealed knowledge about the woman that a stranger could not know (4:16–18; compare 1:48).
- As the woman learned more about Jesus, what she called him showed her increasing understanding:
- At first, she recognized him as "a Jew" (4:9) and called him "Sir" (4:11, 15, 19).
- Later, she thought he might be "the Christ" (4:29), that is, the Messiah (God's chosen one).
- Finally, the people of the village recognized him as "the Savior of the world" (4:42).

Her growing understanding of the identity of Jesus is a lesson for John's audience (see 20:31).

John 4:19–20

The woman did not answer the moral questions that Jesus asked her. Instead, she changed the subject.

She began to speak about the long-standing division between Jews and Samaritans. This conflict included differences about worship and history. By raising this issue, she moved the conversation away from her personal life.

John 4:20

The Samaritans worshiped on Mount Gerizim. This mountain rises above the city of Shechem.

Both Mount Gerizim and Shechem were important places in the Old Testament (see Genesis 12:6–7; 33:19; Deuteronomy 11:29; Joshua 8:33; 24:1, 25, 32).

John 4:21–22

- Jesus affirmed that the Jews had preserved the correct understanding of the one true God whom they worshiped.
- God chose the Jewish people for a special relationship with himself. He gave them his law, his promises, and his covenant (promises between God and his people). The Messiah (God's chosen one) was to come from the Jewish people (see also Romans 9:4–5).

John 4:24

in spirit and in truth: In Greek, one preposition (a connecting word) is used for both words. This shows that spirit and truth form one united idea.

True worship happens when God's Spirit makes God's truth known to a person. Worship is not only about a place or a ceremony. It is about responding to God with the help of his Spirit and according to what is true about him.

Jesus himself is the Truth (14:6). The Spirit is also called the Spirit of truth (14:17; 15:26). Together, the Spirit and the Truth make true worship possible.

John 4:26

I who speak to you am He: Jesus used an unusual and strong form of the words I am.

This wording may point beyond a simple statement of identity. It can suggest a connection with the name of God revealed in the Old Testament (see 8:58; Exodus 3:14).

John 4:27–30

The woman was not fully certain about who Jesus was (4:29). She asked the people of her village, "Could this be the Christ?" Her words show that she was still thinking and learning.

Even so, she ran back to the village and told others about him. She invited them to come and see for themselves.

Telling others about Jesus is a sign of discipleship. Earlier in this Gospel, others also invited people to "come and see"(see 1:39, 46).

John 4:32–34

While Jesus spoke to the Samaritan woman, the disciples had gone to buy food (4:8). When they returned, they urged Jesus to eat. Jesus spoke with symbolic language, but they did not understand him (4:33).

Later, when the disciples received the Holy Spirit, they understood what he meant (2:22). Jesus sustained himself spiritually by doing what his Father told him to do (see 5:30; 6:38; 7:18; 8:50; 9:4; 10:37–38; 12:49–50).

John 4:35

four months until the harvest: Jesus referred to a common saying about farming. Farmers usually waited about four months between planting seed and gathering the crop.

In Samaria, it was likely the time of harvest, and the fields were ready to be gathered. Jesus used this picture to speak about people, not crops.

He had spoken with the woman at the well and planted spiritual seed (God's message). Soon after, many Samaritans believed in him (4:39–42). In this way, Jesus was already gathering a harvest of faith.

John 4:38

others: Jesus might have meant John the Baptist. Or, he might have been referring to the work he had just done with the Samaritan woman.

John 4:39–40

Many of the Samaritans: The religious leaders and teachers in Jerusalem did not respond to Jesus with faith (chapter 3). In contrast, many Samaritans believed in him. They first listened because of the testimony (public witness) of this woman, who had been an outsider in her community. Later, they believed because they heard Jesus for themselves.

John 4:42

The Samaritans had heard Jesus and believed his message for themselves. They were no longer depending only on the woman's testimony.

They called him Savior of the world (see also 1 John 4:14). This title shows that they understood something important. Salvation was not limited to one ethnic group.

As Samaritans, they knew they were separated from the Jews. Yet they recognized that Jesus came for all people. His mission was not only for Jews, but for the whole world (John 1:4–12; compare 12:20–26).

John 4:44–45

Unlike many people in Jerusalem, the Galileans welcomed Jesus when he came to them.

However, their welcome was based on amazement at his miracles (see 2:23–25). They were impressed by what he did.

This response was not yet true faith. True faith trusts in who Jesus is, not only in the signs and wonders he performs.

John 4:48

Jesus strongly criticized the Galileans for asking to see miracles and wonders before they would believe (see 6:30).

John 4:50

"Your son will live": Jesus also healed the centurion's servant and the Phoenician woman's daughter from a distance (Matthew 8:5–13; 15:21–28).

John 4:53

Like many other people, the Jewish official and his household believed in Jesus because of the miracle (2:23; 4:39).

John 4:54

the second sign ... in Galilee: Two miracles at Cana frame for this section of John's Gospel (2:11; 4:46). The first miracle was when Jesus turned water into wine. The second was when he healed the official's son. These two events mark the beginning and the end of this part of the story.

John 5:1

a feast of the Jews: Jesus returned to Jerusalem for this celebration. Because of this, it was likely one of the three main pilgrimage festivals (special festivals when people traveled to Jerusalem).

In the Old Testament, God commanded Israel to celebrate three such festivals each year (see Exodus 23:14–17; Deuteronomy 16:16). These were the Feast of Unleavened Bread (also called Passover), the Feast of Weeks, and the Feast of Tabernacles.

Each of these festivals lasted about one week. During that time, many people gathered in Jerusalem to worship God.

John 5:1–40

This chapter is structured like a courtroom case (a legal trial). It begins with a description of the event that led to the conflict (5:1–15). This is followed by the decision of the Jewish leaders to take action against Jesus (5:16). Next comes a statement of the charges against him (5:18). The chapter then presents the defense given by Jesus, where he explains his authority and his relationship with the Father (5:17, 19–40).

John 5:1–10.42

In this section, Jesus attends several Jewish feasts and uses their imagery to reveal deeper truths about himself.

He appears at:

- a Sabbath feast (chapter 5),
- Passover (chapter 6),
- the Feast of Tabernacles (chapters 7–9), and
- the Feast of Dedication (also called Hanukkah; chapter 10).

In each case, Jesus himself replaces an important element in the ceremonies of the feast.

John 5:2

Greek copyists who had never been to Jerusalem had difficulty interpreting and spelling the name Bethesda, so there are several variants of this name in the manuscripts. The best choice is Beth-esda, which means “house of flowing.”

John 5:3

- The pool of Bethesda was a place for healing where many sick people gathered. They hoped God would cure them with a miracle.
- Some later manuscripts include an additional verse, John 5:4, which explains that an angel stirred the water. This verse is not included in the Berean Standard Bible because it does not appear in the earliest manuscripts of the Gospel of John. The added verse reflects an early tradition that helps explain why people gathered at the pool.

John 5:5

No organized care system existed to help this man. He had been sick for 38 years.

He likely could not keep himself clean. He probably could not move easily on his own. Most likely, he depended on begging from people who came to the pool (see 5:7). From a human point of view, his situation seemed hopeless.

John 5:8–9

- Jesus healed the sick man immediately and only asked him to obey. To prove that the man was healed, Jesus told him to pick up his mat and walk.
- Jesus performed this miracle on the Sabbath. The Sabbath was a weekly day of rest. The law of Moses said that no work should be done on that day (based on Genesis 2:2; Exodus 20:8). Jewish tradition identified 39 types of work that were not allowed (Mishnah Shabbat 7:2). One rule said that a person could not carry an object, such as a sleeping mat, from one place to another (John 5:10).

Jesus told the healed man to pick up his mat and walk. When the man obeyed Jesus, he broke this later Jewish tradition.

John 5:12

Who is this man who told you: The focus of the story now changes. It moves from the joy of a miracle to an accusation about breaking the Sabbath.

The religious leaders wanted to know who told the man to carry his mat. They asked for the name of the healer who had broken their tradition.

John 5:14

Stop sinning: Although Jesus healed this man physically, the man still needed to learn to obey the Lord. The man’s next action (5:15) might indicate that he did not listen.

John 5:17

My Father is at His work, and I too am working: The Sabbath was a day of rest. People were not supposed to work.

However, Jewish teachers agreed that God still worked on the Sabbath. God gives life through birth. God also takes life in death. God’s work does not stop.

Jesus used this idea to explain his actions. He said that, like his Father, he was also working. By speaking this way, Jesus compared himself with God.

The Jewish leaders understood what he meant. They objected because they believed he was claiming a special right that belongs only to God.

John 5:19–30

Jesus claimed that his work on the Sabbath was the same as God's work on the Sabbath. Jesus claimed to be equal with God, doing the things God does. Yet he submitted to God's will, doing only what the Father wanted.

John 5:21

Most Jews firmly believed in resurrection but viewed it as something God alone could accomplish. Jesus claimed that he gives life.

John 5:22

In addition to giving life, Jesus claimed the absolute authority to judge, which belongs to God alone.

John 5:23

the Father who sent Him: In the ancient world, a person could send an authorized representative to seal a contract or make an authoritative decision. Jesus claimed to be God's representative, so obeying Jesus is the same as obeying God, and dishonoring him is dishonoring God.

John 5:24

Jesus is the giver of life as well as the judge (see 5:21–22), but he never works independently of the Father.

John 5:31–40

God's law requires more than one witness in a trial (Deuteronomy 17:6). A single person's word is not enough to prove a case.

Jesus recognized this principle. He said that his own testimony needed support from others.

So he presented several witnesses who confirmed who he was. These witnesses supported his claims and showed that his message was true.

John 5:32

The first witness who spoke in support of Jesus was God himself.

Jesus may have been thinking about the voice from heaven at his baptism, when God said that Jesus was his Son (Mark 1:11). He may also have meant the power of God that worked through him in his miracles.

In both ways, God gave testimony about who Jesus is.

John 5:33–35

The second witness of Jesus was John the Baptist. John pointed to Jesus and said that he is the Messiah (1:29–34).

John 5:36

The third witness of Jesus was his teachings and miracles. These were signs that revealed his true identity and indicated that the Father sent him.

John 5:39–40

The fourth witness of Jesus was the Scriptures. The Old Testament pointed to the Messiah, and Jesus fulfilled its prophecies (see Luke 24:25–27).

John 5:41–47

Jewish trials were meant to discover the truth. The goal was to decide whether the charges were true or false.

If people were falsely accused, they could show that they were innocent. He could also bring charges against those who had accused him. In this situation, Jesus did that.

John 5:42

Jesus said that the Jewish leaders did not have God's love in them. They did not truly love God.

Because they did not love God, they could not understand what Jesus was doing. Without love for God, they were unable to recognize God's work in him.

John 5:44

The Jewish leaders wanted honor and praise from one another. They cared about their reputation and status.

They loved religious activity, but they did not truly love God. Their actions did not match their claims. Because of this, God would judge them (5:45–46).

John 5:45–46

The fifth and final witness for Jesus was Moses, the central figure through whom God gave the law to Israel. Earlier in the Gospel of John, Jesus is compared with Moses, who gave the law, while Jesus brought grace and truth (1:17; see also 6:14–15). The Jewish leaders failed to accept the words of Moses, who spoke clearly about the coming Messiah, including the promise of a prophet like himself (for example, Deuteronomy 18:15).

John 6:1–15

Jesus feeding the 5,000 recalls the Old Testament story of manna (bread from heaven) when Israel was in the wilderness (Exodus 16). In that story, God provided bread each day for his people.

In the time of Jesus, some Jewish teachers believed that the Messiah would again give bread from heaven (Exodus 16:4). They expected a new act of divine provision.

When Jesus fed the crowd, he met this expectation. However, he was not only giving physical bread. He was pointing to himself as the true bread from heaven, who gives life to the world.

John 6:1–71

Each story in this chapter uses the setting of the Feast of the Passover (6:4) to communicate a deeper meaning.

John 6:5

Where can we buy bread: When the Israelites left Egypt after the first Passover and entered the desert, finding food and water was also their first concern (Exodus 15:22–16:3).

John 6:9

Barley was a grain for poor people. The loaves were like pita bread. The two fish were likely salted. Together with the five barley loaves, they made one meal.

John 6:10

The count of about 5,000 included only the men, as was the usual way of counting in that culture (Matthew 14:21). Including women and children, the total number of people was much greater.

John 6:11

The simple meal provided the crowd with as much as they wanted. This was similar to the miracle of manna in the wilderness (Exodus 16:35). In that earlier story, God gave bread from heaven through Moses. Now, Jesus provided bread for the people in a similar way.

John 6:14

Truly this is the Prophet who is to come into the world: The crowd understood the miracle as a fulfillment of Old Testament promises (see Deuteronomy 18:15, 18; Malachi 4:5–6).

John 6:15

they were about to come and make Him king by force: To avoid this role, Jesus fled the crowd and commanded his disciples to go back across the lake (Mark 6:45–46).

John 6:18

Strong east-west winds often blow down from the eastern cliffs of the Sea of Galilee. These winds usually come late in the day.

When the wind rushes down toward the water, it can quickly stir up high waves. As a result, the lake can become very rough and dangerous. Sudden and violent storms were common in that area.

John 6:19

The disciples were afraid of the storm. Then they saw Jesus walking on the water toward them. At that moment, their fear of the storm was replaced by fear and awe of him. Jesus came to help them. By walking on the water, he showed his authority over nature.

This act recalled Moses, who led Israel safely through the water (Exodus 14; see Psalm 77:19–20).

John 6:20

It is I (literally, I am): Jesus identified himself by the name God had revealed to Moses on Mount Sinai (see Exodus 3:14; also see John 4:26; 6:35).

John 6:21

at once the boat reached the shore where they were heading: The healing happened at once. This immediate result was another miracle performed by Jesus.

John 6:24

The crowd sailed north to Capernaum to search for Jesus because he had made Capernaum his home in Galilee (Mark 2:1).

John 6:26

The crowd had decided that Jesus was a prophet. They even wanted to use him for their own political goals (see 6:15).

However, they did not understand the true meaning of the miracle. They focused on the bread and the signs.

Jesus then explained what the miracle really meant. He taught that people should not work only for food that spoils. Instead, they should seek the food that gives eternal life (6:27–59).

John 6:26–59

This dialogue took place in the synagogue at Capernaum shortly before Passover (6:4, 59). During Passover, Jews would read the story of the exodus from Egypt (see Exodus 1–15).

John 6:27

The greatest gift Jesus gives is not physical bread, but eternal life. The Father gave Jesus the authority to do this.

Physical food spoils. But Jesus, who is the bread of life, offers a gift that lasts forever (6:35).

John 6:30

The crowd asked Jesus for another miraculous sign. They wanted proof that he was the Messiah.

Many Jews believed that when the Messiah came, he would repeat the great miracle connected with Moses. They expected manna to fall from heaven again, as it had in the wilderness.

If that happened, people would see it as a second exodus. It would remind them of how God rescued Israel from Egypt and fed them in the desert.

John 6:32–33

Jesus corrected the people's argument: God, not Moses, fed Israel in the wilderness.

The most important goal in life is to seek the true bread from God. This bread is not ordinary food. It is the gift that gives eternal life. To "eat" this bread means to believe in Jesus and depend on him.

Those who receive this bread share in the life that comes from God and lasts forever.

John 6:34

Sir, ... give us this bread: This is similar to the request of the Samaritan woman (4:15). Spiritual awakening begins with a request for God's gift.

John 6:35

- In the Gospel of John, the "I am" statements reveal who Jesus is and what he came to do (see also 4:26; 8:12; 9:5; 10:7–9, 11–14; 11:25; 14:6; 15:1–5). Jesus used the words I am on purpose. These words would remind his listeners of the name of God in the Old Testament (Exodus 3:14).
- I am the bread of life: Jesus is the true manna that came from God (John 6:38). He satisfies the spiritual hunger of those who believe in him (compare 4:10–13).

John 6:37

Everyone the Father gives Me: God acts to bring people to Jesus so that they believe in him.

John 6:37–40

The mission of Jesus is sure to succeed. God sent Jesus and calls people to follow him (6:37, 38, 44). Those who come to him are secure in the promise Jesus gave that he will not reject them or lose them (6:39).

John 6:41–42

- When Jesus called himself the bread that came down from heaven, the crowd had to make a decision.
- Is this not Jesus, the son of Joseph: The people questioned Jesus because they thought they knew him and his family.

Their familiarity with him made his claims seem strange and unbelievable. Since they saw him as an ordinary man from their town, they struggled to accept what he said about himself.

John 6:43–51

Stop grumbling: Instead of defending himself against their complaint, Jesus addresses their lack of spiritual receptivity (their openness to God; see 6:42). Those who love the Father and listen to him will believe in Jesus.

John 6:49–50

Jesus connected the manna of the exodus story with himself. Then he said why he was different from the manna the Israelites received from God.

The Israelites remained mortal and they all died. But the bread from heaven (Jesus himself) provides eternal life (6:47, 51, 58).

John 6:51

this bread ... is My flesh: The gift that gives life is now made clear. On the cross, Jesus gave his body so that the world might receive life.

John 6:53–58

eats My flesh and drinks My blood: Jesus answered the question the people asked (6:52). His words pointed ahead to the Lord's Supper, which would come later (see Luke 22:19). In Jewish speech, the phrase "flesh and blood" referred to the whole person. In this con-

text, Jesus was calling people to receive him fully by completely believing in him.

Ever since the Protestant Reformation, there have been three main interpretations of the words of Jesus about the bread and wine:

1. Transubstantiation: The bread and wine are believed to change into the actual body and blood of Christ, while still appearing to be bread and wine.
2. Real Presence: Christ is understood to be truly present in the sacrament in a mysterious but real way that is beyond human understanding.
3. Memorial or Symbolic View: The bread and wine are seen as symbols. The act of sharing them recalls Christ's death and resurrection, and believers receive spiritual benefit through faith.

John 6:60–61

What Jesus said was shocking and offensive (6:53–58; see Genesis 9:4–5). It was hard for his disciples and the crowd to understand. Should they take him literally? How could they eat his flesh? Jesus answers in John 6:63.

John 6:63

The true source of the gift Jesus gives is the Holy Spirit, not human effort. In this context, the flesh refers to what humans can do on their own. Life and understanding come through the gift of the Spirit (see 14:15–20; 20:21–22). True life is found only when the Holy Spirit gives life to people.

John 6:65

no one can come to Me unless the Father has granted it to him (see 6:44): Only God's light can shine into the deep darkness of the world.

John 6:68–69

Simon Peter often spoke on behalf of the 12 apostles (see also Matthew 14:28–29; 16:16; 17:4; 18:21; 19:27; 26:33–35).

John 6:70–71

- Once again, Jesus showed supernatural knowledge (knowledge beyond normal human ability; see 1:47–49; 4:16–19). He knew what was in people's hearts (their innermost selves) and what would happen in the future.

Jesus knew that Judas would betray him. Judas later betrayed Jesus to the authorities (12:4; 13:2; Matthew 26:14–16).

- Iscariot means "man from Kerioth." Kerioth was the home village of Judas's family.

John 7:1–52

This chapter describes Jesus at the Jewish Feast of Tabernacles. Jesus used parts of the feast to reveal his true identity to his fellow Jews and to show that he had fulfilled the feast's essential meaning (see 7:37–39; 8:12).

John 7:2

The law of Moses required Jewish men to come to the temple for the Feast of Tabernacles (Exodus 23:14–17; Deuteronomy 16:16). This annual seven-day autumn harvest feast happened in Jerusalem six months after Passover (John 6:4).

During the feast, people lived in temporary shelters to remember the tents Israel used during their 40 years in the wilderness.

John 7:3–5

The brothers of Jesus reminded him of his religious duty to go to the festival (see also Mark 3:31). Their words carried a cynical tone because at this time they did not believe in him (John 7:5).

John 7:6–8

My time has not yet come: Jesus said that it was not the right time for him to go publicly to Jerusalem.

Later, however, he did go to the city. He went quietly and not in a public way (7:10; compare study note on 12:23).

John 7:15

They wondered how he could teach with such understanding.

Jesus had not studied under a well-known rabbi (a Jewish teacher of the law). Instead, he said that his teaching came from his heavenly Father.

This was different from many Jewish teachers. For example, Peter and John were known as untrained men (Acts 4:13). In contrast, Paul had studied under a respected teacher (Acts 22:3).

John 7:17

People who truly want to follow God's will accept Jesus and his teachings (see also 5:42–47).

In contrast, those who focus only on the values and desires of this world are not open to Christ. When people care more about human approval, power, or

temporary success, they struggle to receive his message.

John 7:19

Has not Moses given you the law? Yet not one of you keeps it: The Jewish leaders were proud of the law of Moses. They believed they carefully obeyed it.

However, Jesus pointed out a serious problem. While they honored the law in words, they were planning to kill him. In doing so, they were breaking the law (Exodus 20:13).

John 7:20

You have a demon: See 8:48–52; 10:20–21.

John 7:22

The law required circumcision on the eighth day (Leviticus 12:3). It allowed a boy to be circumcised even if that day was the Sabbath.

Jesus argued in the way many rabbis did. They reasoned from the lesser to the greater. If a smaller religious act, such as circumcision, was allowed on the Sabbath, then a greater act, such as making a whole person well, should also be allowed.

John 7:27

Some people in the crowd believed they knew where Jesus came from. Because they could trace his earthly origins, they thought he could not be the Messiah.

They expected the Messiah to appear suddenly and in a mysterious way. Since Jesus had grown up among them, they assumed he did not fit their expectations.

John 7:29

I am from Him: Instead of answering questions about where he grew up (7:27, 40–44), Jesus spoke about where he truly came from. He pointed to his heavenly origin.

He said that he was sent by God. This was a bold claim.

The religious leaders understood what he meant. Because of this, they tried to arrest him. They believed he was speaking in a way that dishonored God (7:30; compare 10:30–33).

John 7:30

His hour had not yet come: Those who opposed Jesus could not arrest him. This was because, according to God's plan, the time for Jesus to be glorified on the cross had not yet come (see study note on 12:23; see also 10:17–18; 18:6–8).

All four arrest scenes in 7:1–8:59 emphasize that Jesus was in control, not the Jewish leaders.

John 7:32–36

- Jesus announced his return to the one who sent him, the Father in heaven (17:1–7). But the Pharisees misunderstood him. They thought he was leaving Judea to visit the Gentiles (non-Jewish people). These were people whom Pharisees would never visit.
- After Jesus returned to the Father, the Jewish leaders would no longer be able to find him.
- and where I am, you cannot come: These Pharisees, still in spiritual darkness, could not enter heaven. So Jesus would be beyond their reach there.

John 7:37–38

- Living water: See 4:10–14. A water ceremony was held each day during the Feast of Tabernacles, with prayer for God to send rain in the late autumn.

The final day, called the great day, was the feast's most important moment. On this day, they repeated the ceremony seven times. They poured water over the altar while Levites sang Isaiah 12:3 (see Zechariah 14:8; see also Mishnah Sukkah chapter 4).

- If anyone is thirsty, let him come to Me and drink: Jesus fulfilled an important part of the Feast of Tabernacles. He himself is the source of living water, available to anyone who believes.

John 7:39

In the death and resurrection of Jesus, his life was given for others, and the Holy Spirit was given to believers.

When Jesus was crucified, blood and water flowed from his side (see 19:34). This event points to the gift of life that comes through his death.

After he rose from the dead, he breathed on his disciples and gave them the Holy Spirit (20:22). In this way, his life and the Spirit were poured out for his followers.

John 7:41–42

These Jews were not like the crowd who thought the Christ (the Messiah) would have a mysterious appearance (7:25–27). They believed the prophecy that God's chosen ruler would come from Bethlehem in Judea (see Micah 5:2). However, they struggled with the fact that Jesus seemed to be from Galilee, where he grew up.

John 7:45–52

- The story ends with Jewish leaders feeling frustrated and the people being divided over their opinion of Jesus (compare 7:25–27, 31–32).
- officers returned: See 7:32.

John 7:49–51

Nicodemus was likely starting to believe in Jesus (see 3:1–21; 19:38–42). Some leaders claimed that none of the Pharisees believed in Jesus (7:48). They spoke as if only the crowd, whom the leaders believed did not understand the law, supported him.

However, Nicodemus shows that this was not completely true. Not only the people in the crowd, but also some Pharisees were beginning to believe in him.

John 7:52

no prophet comes out of Galilee: The Jewish leaders were apparently unaware that Jesus had been born in Bethlehem of Judea, not in Galilee (see Matthew 2:1; Luke 2:1–7).

John 7:53–8.11

It is likely that someone added this story to John's Gospel later, since it is not in the earliest Greek manuscripts. However, it is likely a true story from the life of Jesus.

John 8:3

The scribes and Pharisees: The teachers of religious law were Jewish scholars. They specialized in the Old Testament law and oral traditions that explained it.

John 8:4

The form of the Greek sentence emphasizes the legal claim against the woman. She had been caught while committing the sin of adultery. The law required two witnesses and carefully outlined what evidence was needed.

John 8:5

- In the Law Moses commanded us to stone: This suggests the woman was engaged or married (Leviticus 20:10; Deuteronomy 22:23–24). The law also indicates that the man who sinned with her must die as well. But these Jewish religious leaders ignored that part of the law.
- They could have dealt with the situation privately to avoid shaming her. But their real intention was to condemn Jesus instead. They asked him, So what do you say?

Would he neglect the law since he had a reputation for mercy? Or would he ignore the woman's tragedy?

John 8:6

We cannot know what Jesus wrote in the dust. Some scholars suggest he wrote down the sins of those who were accusing the woman.

John 8:7

The answer Jesus gave did not mean that someone who makes an accusation must be morally perfect to make legal claims. He referred to him who is without sin to point to the motives of those accusing her.

John 8:9

they began to go away one by one: One of the people accusing her left, then another, followed by several people who had been standing there watching what was happening.

John 8:11

neither do I: Jesus spoke words of assurance, but this did not suggest that the woman was innocent. Jesus takes sin and judgment seriously, but he shows grace and forgiveness to those overcome by sin.

John 8:12

During the Festival of Tabernacles, people filled 16 gold bowls in the temple's inner courts with oil and lit them. Jesus stood under these lights in the temple and said that he was now the source of the light of the world (8:20). The light of Jesus brings salvation to both Israel and the world, regardless of race or location.

John 8:12–59

The debate about whether Jesus is the Messiah continues from 7:52. Jesus remained at the Feast of Tabernacles in Jerusalem. During the feast, the conflicts Jesus encountered in chapter 7 continued and intensified.

John 8:13

The Pharisees argued that what Jesus was saying about himself was not valid because Jewish law requires more than one witness (Deuteronomy 19:15; compare John 5:31–32; see 8:17).

John 8:14–15

Jesus responded to the Pharisees' accusations. He said he could make these claims about himself because he knew both his origin and his destination

were heaven. He then said the most important witness for his case was his Father who sent him (8:16).

John 8:19

Throughout the feast, those listening to Jesus proved they were in darkness as they misunderstood him. They wanted to meet the father of Jesus, who is God. Since they did not truly know God, they were unable to understand Jesus.

John 8:20

- The treasury was in the section of the temple called the Court of the Women. Jesus often taught there so both men and women could listen (Mark 12:41).
- His hour: See notes on John 2:4; 12:23.

John 8:21

In the earlier debate at the feast, people questioned where Jesus came from (7:27). Here, Jesus talked about returning to where he came from (heaven). However, once again, his words were misunderstood by the people listening.

John 8:23

Jesus told his listeners that they were from below, while he was from above (3:31; see study note on 3:3).

From below refers to human life limited to this world. From above refers to heaven and to God's realm.

Because they were thinking only in earthly terms, they could not understand what Jesus meant. His origin and authority came from God.

John 8:24

- unless you believe that I am He: Jesus used God's divine name (see 4:26; Exodus 3:14). His listeners did not fully understand the meaning of his words (John 8:25).
- die in your sins: Jesus is the light who has come into the world. His presence offers the only way of salvation. If people reject him, they remain in darkness and do not receive life.

John 8:25

Who are you?: Later, they understood what he was claiming about himself. They believed he was showing dishonor toward God. Because of this, they tried to stone him (8:59).

John 8:28

The Synoptic Gospels describe Jesus as predicting his death three times (for example, Mark 8:31; 9:31; 10:33–34).

The Gospel of John presents this theme in a different way. Jesus speaks about being lifted up (John 3:14; 8:28; 12:33–34). This phrase refers to his crucifixion and also to his glory. The Father directs the course of events. The death of Jesus did not happen by accident, but according to God's plan.

John 8:30

Once again, the crowd at the feast was divided. Earlier, the discussion had ended with plans to arrest Jesus (8:20). Now many people believed in him. They were persuaded that he was speaking the truth.

However, when Jesus spoke more clearly about who he really was, their faith was tested. As his full identity became known, some struggled to accept his words (8:31–59).

John 8:31–32

- Discipleship involves more than just knowing who Jesus is. It also requires obeying his teachings (3:36; 14:15, 21, 23; 15:10).
- Because Jesus is the truth, knowing him helps a person understand what is true and what is false (14:6).
- set you free: The truth frees a person from darkness, lies, and sin.

John 8:33

- Jesus challenged a common belief about Israel as God's chosen people. Many thought that being descendants of Abraham gave them special privilege and protection.

Instead of seeing this heritage as a responsibility to obey God, some treated it as a guarantee of safety. However, the prophets had warned that privilege brings accountability (compare Amos 3:1–15).

- The people did not understand what Jesus meant by set free. He was not talking about freedom from human slavery. He meant freedom from spiritual slavery to sin (John 8:34).

True freedom comes through the truth. It does not come from family history or religious background (8:32; Romans 6:17; 8:2; 1 John 3:4, 8, 9).

John 8:35

Jesus explained his argument: If Israel is a spiritual slave, it has the same insecurity as any slave in a household. Family members are secure, but slaves are not. Only Jesus can change the status of those in spiritual slavery, making them free and secure.

John 8:37–41

The leaders' plan to kill Jesus revealed their true identity (5:18). They were part of a different spiritual family, and their spiritual father was not Jesus's Father. They were relying on the fact that their ancestral father was Abraham, but Jesus challenged their spiritual heritage.

The most important part of his challenge comes in 8:44.

John 8:41

- your father: Jesus knew who controlled them.
- We are not illegitimate children: This statement acted as both a defense and an attack. The Greek text emphasizes the pronoun we. In other words, "We [in contrast to you] are not illegitimate." They are suggesting that Jesus was illegitimate (see Matthew 1:18–25).

John 8:44

Since the unbelieving people did not love Jesus (8:42; 1 John 5:1), they were not children of the Father in heaven who sent his beloved Son (John 8:47). Their desire to kill God's Son showed their true spiritual heritage. This was the work of the devil, who brought death to the world (see Genesis 3:1–20; Romans 5:12–14).

John 8:48–49

By calling Jesus a Samaritan with a demon, his opponents used a racial insult to dismiss his accusations (see study note on 4:4–6). They claimed Jesus was demon-possessed to counter his claim that they belonged to Satan (also 7:20; 8:52; 10:20; 8:44).

Jesus rightly replied that these words were deeply offensive. In fact, it was a serious and unforgivable offense (Mark 3:22–29).

John 8:53

Who do You claim to be?: This question was hostile and aggressive. However, if Jesus is immortal, ruling over life and death, then he is greater than Abraham, the prophets, or any of the greatest people in Israel's history (8:58).

John 8:56

Like his opponents, Jesus appealed to Abraham. Rabbis taught that God had given Abraham prophetic insight, teaching him about the coming age of the Messiah.

John 8:57

You are not yet fifty years old: The Jewish leaders misunderstood Jesus. Jesus was not talking about his physical age. He was speaking about his divine preexistence (his existence before he was born as a human).

John 8:58

- before Abraham was born, I am!: The life of Jesus spans the past from before creation and continues forever (1:1–2).
- I am: This title recalls the name of God revealed to Moses at Mount Sinai (Exodus 3:14; compare John 4:26; Isaiah 43:11–13; 48:12).

John 8:59

- Those listening to Jesus finally understood his claim to be God (8:58). Because of this, they became very angry. They believed they had heard blasphemy (words that dishonored God) and picked up stones to throw at him, which was the proper legal response (Leviticus 24:16).
- Jesus was hidden from them because God had chosen a different time for his death (see study note on John 12:23; see also 7:30, 44; Luke 4:29–30).

John 9:1–41

At the Feast of Tabernacles, Jesus claimed to be the light of the world (chapters 7–8; see 8:12). Now John tells about Jesus giving light, both physically and spiritually, to a blind man who lived in darkness (see 9:5).

The story ends with a surprising reversal (a complete change) of roles: The man who had been blind was assumed to live in spiritual darkness. Yet he came to see and accept God's light. The Pharisees could see with their physical eyes. People thought they were spiritually enlightened (well taught and wise). However, they refused to believe. In the end, they were shown to be spiritually blind.

John 9:2

The disciples thought the man was born blind because of sin, either his own sin or his parents'. Jesus corrected this common belief (9:3).

John 9:5

I am the light of the world: See study note on 8:12.

John 9:6

During the New Testament era, saliva was used for medical purposes (see Mark 7:32–35; 8:22–25).

John 9:7

- Siloam, a pool at the south end of Jerusalem, provided water for the Feast of Tabernacles ceremonies.
- which means "Sent": This phrase contained a double meaning: Jesus, who has been sent by God, told the blind man to wash in the pool called Sent (4:34; 5:23, 37; 7:28; 8:26; 12:44; 14:24).

John 9:11

The blind man recognized Jesus and spoke with confidence about him. Jesus healed the man of his physical problem, and the man gained more spiritual understanding (9:17, 33). He became a disciple of Jesus (9:38; compare 5:11–15).

John 9:13

The Pharisees were experts in interpreting the Jewish law. So the community asked them to explain this miracle (see 1:24). Instead of celebrating the healing, these religious leaders questioned the man because Jesus had performed the miracle on the Sabbath (see 5:16–18).

John 9:17

The man had already identified his healer (9:11, 16). Now he made his own spiritual judgment, calling Jesus a prophet.

John 9:18

The Pharisees wanted to dismiss the miracle. They did not want to accept that Jesus had truly healed the man.

They called the man's parents and questioned them. They hoped the parents would deny that a real healing had taken place.

John 9:20–22

His parents confirmed that their son had been born blind, but they hesitated to judge how he could see because they were afraid of the social consequences.

John 9:24

Give glory to God!: Compare Joshua 7:19.

John 9:28–29

- The Pharisees could not argue against the logic of the miracle (9:24–25, 30–33). So they abandoned reason and cursed him (see 9:34).
- The harsh division between Jesus and the religious leaders was clear. They considered those who followed Jesus to have rejected Moses and Judaism.

John 9:30

The Jewish leaders did not know where Jesus came from. It made sense that the man was amazed. A healing like this had never happened before.

The work of Jesus showed he was from God. Once people knew who he truly was, they should have believed and followed him. However, the Jewish leaders chose to ignore the truth.

John 9:32–33

Only God could give sight to someone born blind. By healing the man, Jesus gave the Jewish leaders an obvious sign that he was from God and was the Messiah (compare Psalm 146:8; Isaiah 35:5; 42:7).

John 9:34

Discipline such as being thrown out of the synagogue was not uncommon. It brought social isolation that might require the man's departure from the village. Such serious persecution was precisely what Jesus predicted for his followers (15:18–27; 16:2).

John 9:35

Son of Man: See 1:51; 3:13, 14; 5:27; 6:27, 53, 62; 8:28. The Greek expression translates a Hebrew and Aramaic phrase that means human being. People were often unsure what Jesus meant when he used this title (see 12:34). In Daniel 7:13–14, a human figure receives authority and an eternal kingdom from God. Later Jewish tradition connected this figure with hopes for the Messiah. John uses the title Son of Man to point to Jesus as both an ordinary human being and the Messiah appointed by God.

John 9:35–38

Jesus urged the man who had been blind to understand the miracle and recognize the one who healed him. The man immediately showed faith and honored Jesus in the same way he would honor God (9:38; compare 20:28).

John 9:40–41

Are we blind too?: Jesus answered that those who claim to hold all religious truth will discover that they are blind, while those who recognize their spiritual poverty will find true sight. In the story, the blind man and his family frequently confessed that they did not know, while the Pharisees repeatedly stated their confidence and remained guilty because of their religious pride. If they had confessed their ignorance and admitted their spiritual blindness, they would be guiltless. Instead, their conscious and willful rejection of Jesus established their guilt.

John 10:1

- A shepherd in the wild would build a sheepfold. This was a pen with low stone walls topped by sharp branches, to keep his sheep safe at night.
- The pen had one gate (or opening in the wall) that was closed with branches. Any person or thing that came into the pen threatened the flock.
- A bad shepherd was like a thief and a robber. He used the sheep for his own gain and did not care for them. Bad shepherds took the sheep's milk and wool for themselves. They killed the sheep without guaranteeing their safety (Ezekiel 34:3; see Isaiah 56:11; Jeremiah 23:1–4).

These words were the strongest rebuke Jesus spoke against the Jewish leaders.

John 10:1–21

This illustration of a shepherd and his sheep comes from a Middle Eastern perspective of shepherding and Old Testament traditions in first-century AD Jewish culture. God was the shepherd of Israel (Genesis 49:24; Psalms 23; 78:52–53; Isaiah 40:10–11).

Spiritual and political leaders of Israel were also shepherds of God's people, the flock of God (Isaiah 56:9–12; Jeremiah 23:1–4; Ezekiel 34).

Jesus spoke these words during the Feast of Dedication (see John 10:22). At that time, people remembered both faithful and unfaithful leaders in Israel's history.

In this setting, Jesus addressed the theme of shepherds. He spoke in a way that echoes Ezekiel 34, where God condemns bad shepherds and promises to care for his people himself. Jesus then identified himself as the good shepherd (John 10:11–14).

John 10:1–42

Chapter 10 continues the series of feast sermons (see study note on 5:1–10:42). Here, the setting is the Feast of Dedication. The timing of this feast is important for understanding the story (see study note on 10:22).

John 10:3

the sheep listen for his voice: The Middle Eastern shepherd is well known for having intimate knowledge of the sheep. Sheep are led with flute tunes, songs, or verbal commands.

John 10:4

A good shepherd goes ahead of the sheep and leads them. He does not force them from behind. When the sheep recognize his voice, they trust him and follow.

John 10:7

I am: See study note on 6:35. A good shepherd protects the sheep at the gate like a guard.

John 10:9

he will be saved (or will find safety): As the guard at the gate, Jesus protects his sheep from harm by keeping them safe inside the pen.

John 10:10

The followers of Jesus must be wary of bad shepherds who desire to steal and kill and destroy. When they told the story of the Feast of Dedication to the Jewish people, it reminded them of false religious leaders (see study note on 10:22). The failures of these leaders had led to the loss of God's temple in Jerusalem during the time of the Maccabean Revolt.

John 10:11–13

Small villages often created communal flocks and employed a hired hand to tend the sheep. However, an employee lacked the commitment of a true shepherd. The wilderness of Judea had many predators. When a wolf or other predators attacked, the hired hand would run rather than defend the sheep. Jesus will never do this; he will always stand between his sheep and danger.

John 10:11–14

I am: See study note on 6:35. The good shepherd guides his sheep, finds food and water, and locates paths in the wilderness (see Psalm 23). The good shepherd stands between his sheep and danger (John 10:11).

The Old Testament describes God as Israel's shepherd (Psalms 23; 80:1; Isaiah 40:10–11). The religious leaders of God's people should care for their flock as God does

(Ezekiel 34:23). However, the leaders of Israel in the time of Jesus were not good shepherds.

John 10:14–17

I give my life for the sheep: Jesus was speaking about his coming death. He was referring to his crucifixion (his death on a cross; chapter 19).

John 10:15

The Father and the Son have an intimate relationship. Jesus shares a similar relationship with his sheep (his followers) through the Holy Spirit (14:23–31; 15:1–11).

John 10:16

other sheep: Jesus spoke about sheep who were not part of the present sheepfold. This refers to people outside Judaism who would later believe in him (see 11:52). The followers of Jesus would not be divided by ethnic background. Jewish and Gentile believers from many cultures would become one flock. There would be one shepherd and one united people (17:20–23).

John 10:18

- No one takes it from Me: The death of the Son was voluntary. Jesus was not a helpless victim of events beyond his control. He chose to give his life freely in obedience and close relationship with the Father (see Acts 2:23–24).
- The resurrection of Jesus was not an afterthought or a rescue from failure. God cannot be confined by death or a tomb. Because Jesus and the Father are one, Jesus possessed the authority to rise from death.

John 10:19–21

- Jesus divided his audience yet again (see also 6:66–69; 7:43; 9:16). His words and actions led people to one of two responses: opposition or faith.
- He is demon-possessed: Compare 7:20; 8:48–49, 52.

John 10:22

the Feast of Dedication: This winter feast is also known as Hanukkah. It celebrates the time when the Jews rededicated the temple after Antiochus IV (175–163 BC) defiled it in. Two hundred years before Jesus was born, Greek soldiers captured the Jerusalem Temple, stole its treasures, and made it unusable for worship.

In the winter of 165–164 BC, a Jewish army led by Judas Maccabeus reclaimed the temple and rededicated it to the Lord. The Feast of Hanukkah ("dedication") celebrates this event (see 1 Maccabees 3–4; 2 Maccabees 8:1–10:8).

During the feast, priests examined their commitment to service, using Ezekiel 34 as their main text for reflection (also Jeremiah 23:1–4; 25:32–38; Zechariah 11). At this Hanukkah celebration, Jesus used the shepherd theme from Ezekiel 34 to show he was the good shepherd (John 10:11). He also showed how Israel's current religious leaders were bad shepherds (10:10, 12–13).

John 10:23

Large covered walkways with rows of columns stood around all four sides of the temple's central courtyard. These structures are called colonnades.

Solomon's Colonnade was on the east side. It provided shelter from wind and rain, especially during the winter months.

John 10:24

The people around Jesus might have been trying to understand, or they might have been hostile. In Luke 21:20 and Hebrews 11:30, the same word describes how armies surrounded Jerusalem and Jericho before their destruction. In Acts 14:20, it refers to Paul's disciples gathering around him after he was injured.

John 10:25

Jesus had already provided the Jewish people and their religious leaders with sufficient proof that he is the Son of God. The problem was not lack of information, but their unwillingness to believe him.

John 10:25–42

In his final public statement in this Gospel, Jesus gave a clear and complete declaration about who he is (10:30). He spoke openly about his unity with the Father.

This statement brought his public teaching to a high point and made his identity unmistakable.

John 10:27–29

- As the good shepherd, Jesus would die for his sheep and protect them from all predators and thieves (10:1, 8, 11; see Ezekiel 34:22–23).
- The Father's power, shown through Jesus, keeps his sheep safe. No one can steal from Jesus those who trust in him. This is because no one is stronger than Jesus. Their security depends on Christ, not their own efforts.
- The word translated as snatch suggests violence (as in John 6:15).

John 10:30

The Father and the Son are distinct persons, yet they share one purpose and one divine nature (1:1, 14; 14:9; 20:28). They are not the same person. Yet they are united in will, authority, and being.

Because of this unity, Jesus has the power to protect God's flock (10:28–29). His words are a strong statement about his divinity.

John 10:31–33

The people understood what Jesus meant and wanted to kill him (see 10:33). The problem was not that Jesus performed good works, but that he claimed to be God (see 6:42, 60; 7:29–30). Blasphemy (speaking in a way that dishonors God) was punishable by death under the law of Moses. The required punishment was stoning (see Leviticus 24:23; John 8:59).

John 10:34–36

'I have said you are gods': If the word gods could describe people other than the Lord, then Jesus was not breaking the law by referring to himself in this way. But Jesus is not just any son of God. Jesus is the Son of God who the Father sent into the world.

John 10:38

The miraculous works Jesus performed should help true believers know and understand that the full reality of God dwells in Jesus.

John 10:40

His revelation to the Jewish leaders now complete, Jesus went to the region beyond the Jordan River where John the Baptist had once worked and where Jesus was baptized.

John 10:41

everything he said about this man was true: See 1:19–51; 3:22–36. The fulfillment of John the Baptist's predictions confirms both that he was a prophet and that what he said about Jesus was true.

John 10:42

This is a note of irony (an unexpected contrast). In Jerusalem, the holy city, Jesus found little faith among the religious leaders. But in the desert, away from the center of religious power, many people believed in him.

John 11:1

- In the Hebrew language, Lazarus is a shortened form of Eleazar, which means "God helps." In the first century, it was the fourth most common name for Jewish men (see also Luke 16:19–31).
- Bethany was a small village east of Jerusalem, just past the Mount of Olives (John 11:18). Jesus often stayed there when he visited Jerusalem. He likely traveled through Bethany on his way to Jerusalem. This was because most Jews from Galilee took a route going south to Jericho, then west to Jerusalem.
- Mary and Martha were sisters (see Luke 10:38–42). Martha was probably older. She was the host in Luke's Gospel and represented the family. Mary later anointed Jesus with perfume (John 12:1–8).

John 11:1–57

The resurrection of Lazarus points to the future death and resurrection of Jesus. The description of Lazarus's tomb is similar to the description of the tomb Jesus was placed in after he died (11:38, 44; 20:1, 7). Both accounts mention a cave and burial cloths. These details connect the two events and help us see that Lazarus's story is a sign.

Soon after Lazarus was raised, a woman anointed Jesus for burial (12:3). This act prepared him for his coming death.

Then the time for his glorification began (12:23).

John 11:3

The two sisters had a difficult choice to make. They knew Jesus was able to heal, but they also realized that his return to Judea would involve personal risk (11:8).

John 11:4

Jesus responded with words that were similar to his words about the man born blind (9:1–5). Jesus already knew Lazarus was dead (11:14). He was talking about Lazarus's resurrection, which would bring glory to God (11:43).

John 11:6

The trip to Bethany from where Jesus was staying would have taken only one day (see 10:40). However, Jesus followed his own timing and did not let others rush him (2:4; 7:5–9).

John 11:8

The disciples were rightly worried about the risk (see 7:25; 8:37, 44, 59; 10:31, 39).

John 11:16

- Thomas: See also 14:5; 20:24; 21:2; Mark 3:18.
- Let us also go, so that we may die: Thomas knew that earlier visits to Judea had been risky (John 5:18; 10:31, 39). Traveling to Jerusalem now would likely mean death for Jesus (compare 11:49–50).

John 11:17

In Jewish custom at that time, people were usually buried on the same day they died. Families placed the body in a tomb quickly, often within hours.

John tells us that Lazarus had been in the tomb for four days. This detail is important. It shows that Lazarus was truly dead.

Because four days had passed, this miracle was not a simple resuscitation (bringing someone back who only seemed dead). Jesus did not restore a weak person who might recover. He raised a man who had been dead and buried for several days.

John 11:19

Life in New Testament times was lived publicly. Lazarus's large extended family, as well as the villagers, had arrived for a seven-day mourning period. To console the sisters in their loss, there was great wailing and crying (see 11:33 and corresponding study note).

John 11:21

Lord, if You had been here: Mary later repeated Martha's words (11:32), because both sisters knew that Jesus had a reputation as a healer. They concluded that Jesus would have healed Lazarus, but they did not imagine that Jesus would restore him from death.

John 11:22

whatever You ask of Him: Martha believed Jesus could still help in some way. Despite this, she objected when Jesus wanted to open the tomb (11:39). She did not think Jesus would resurrect her brother from the dead.

John 11:24

rise again in the resurrection at the last day: Martha misunderstood Jesus because she thought he meant the general resurrection of all dead people at the end of time (compare 11:11–13).

John 11:25

- Jesus helped Martha believe in him not only as someone who heals, but as someone who defeats death.
- I am the resurrection and the life: Victory over death comes from living in union with Jesus. Although the followers of Jesus will one day die, they will have eternal life after death. For more on the I am statements of Jesus, see the study note on 6:35.

John 11:26–27

- Do you believe this?: Jesus was not simply asking Martha if he could bring Lazarus out of the grave. Martha already believed that Lazarus would rise again on the last day.

Instead, Jesus asked a deeper question. Did Martha believe that life itself is connected to him?

- "Yes, Lord": Even though she did not fully understand, she acknowledged that Jesus was the Christ, God's chosen one. But she was still surprised by his power.

John 11:28–32

Mary now joined the scene on the edge of the village, repeating her sister's cry of misery. She fell at the feet of Jesus, not in worship but in desperate grief.

John 11:33

- Loud weeping and crying out were common public displays of grief in this culture, as was beating one's chest (Mark 5:38; Luke 18:13).
- The Greek word translated deeply moved in spirit describes strong human emotion, including outrage or anger. Jesus was not angry at Martha or Mary. Jesus was angry because the situation showed the people's lack of belief, even though resurrection was real and near.

John 11:39

Lazarus was buried in a tomb cut from the rocky hillside; such tombs were common. The tomb was closed and opened for further burials with a rolling stone that covered the entrance. A central door led to a cave room where burial benches were carved in stone along the inner wall. Horizontal burial chambers were cut along the top edge of the benches.

John 11:45–46

News of the miracle quickly spread to Jerusalem (12:9, 17). Again, people had different opinions about who Jesus was (6:66–69; 7:43; 9:16; 10:19; 11:37). Jesus was

famous in Galilee for healing and raising the dead (see Matthew 9:24–26; 10:8; 11:5). Now he had brought this power to Judea.

John 11:48

The council met to discuss what to do about Jesus. During their discussion, they revealed their fear. They were afraid that everyone would believe in him.

If many people believed that Jesus was the Messiah (God's chosen one), this could cause political trouble. In that time, the Romans ruled over Judea. They did not tolerate leaders who claimed to be kings.

The Romans viewed Jewish messiahs with suspicion. They feared rebellion. The council worried that the growing movement around Jesus might lead the Romans to attack Jerusalem and destroy the temple.

So their concern was not only religious. It was also political. They feared losing their place, their authority, and even their nation.

John 11:49

Caiaphas was the ruler of the high council from AD 18–36. He worked for ten years alongside Pontius Pilate, governor of Judea (AD 26–36; see 18:29), keeping the peace with Rome.

John 11:50–51

it is better ... that one man die: Caiaphas spoke with clear political intent. He argued that it was better for one man to die than for the whole nation to suffer. He meant that it was better for Jesus, whom he saw as a threat, to die than for Rome to destroy the Jewish people.

Caiaphas viewed Jesus as a possible revolutionary. He feared that Rome would crush the nation if unrest grew. From his point of view, sacrificing one man would protect many.

But his words carried a deeper meaning. Caiaphas did not understand this meaning. In a way he could not see, he spoke the truth. Jesus would die for the people. His death would bring salvation (rescue from sin and separation from God).

John explains that Caiaphas did not speak on his own authority. As high priest that year, he spoke prophetically (as one who speaks a message from God). God used his words to point to the saving purpose of the death of Jesus.

The rescue that God's people needed was not mainly from Rome. It would come through the cross of Christ.

John 11:52

Christ's death was not for Israel only, but for all, including people of other cultures all across the world (10:16; 12:32).

John 11:53–54

- When the Jewish leaders started planning to kill Jesus, Jesus responded carefully (11:54). He did not act in fear, but he acted wisely. He chose to leave the area for a time.
- Ephraim was a village about 19 kilometers (12 miles) north of Jerusalem. Jesus was safe there from the Sanhedrin but close enough to walk to the Passover feast that was happening soon (11:55).

John 11:55–57

As crowds arrived in Jerusalem on pilgrimage for Passover (see 2:13), the city was buzzing with talk about Jesus and his miracle of raising Lazarus from the dead. People wondered if Jesus would be obedient to the law and come to the city to celebrate or play it safe in the countryside. The priests and Pharisees knew that Jesus was faithful to the law and would attend the festival, so they tried to make the city a trap for him.

John 12:1

Pilgrims from throughout Israel began arriving in Jerusalem the week before the Passover. The festival was on Thursday that year. Jesus arrived in the area late on the previous Friday, just before the Sabbath.

John 12:1–50

- In this part of John's Gospel, two stories move forward at the same time.

First, more and more people begin to praise Jesus. Their excitement reaches a high point when crowds welcome him into Jerusalem with shouts of joy (12:12–13).

Second, the religious authorities become more determined to arrest Jesus and put him to death. As public support grows, their opposition grows as well.

- John's Gospel describes three events that happened only days before Passover (12:1–11, 12–19, 20–36). Then he explains why most of the people refused to believe and describes the final public message spoken by Jesus (12:37–50).

John 12:2

those reclining: People usually sat or leaned back at a low table while eating.

John 12:3

- Mary ... anointed Jesus' feet. This was not awkward because Jews reclined at formal meals, but it was still a dramatic gesture (compare Matthew 26:6–16; Mark 14:3–9).
- Nard was a valuable spice from North India. It was sweet, red, and smelled like the perfume made from the gladiola plant. Twelve ounces of nard cost one year's wages (John 12:5).

According to Mark's Gospel, Mary also anointed the head of Jesus (Mark 14:3). The perfume ran down and made his clothes smell good (Mark 14:8).

- her hair: Women never took their hair covering off in public (see Luke 7:38). Mary was acting with deep and costly devotion.

John 12:5

three hundred denarii: Judas may have been exaggerating, but Mary's sacrifice was certainly very costly.

John 12:7

Leave her alone: Jesus defended Mary by explaining her actions. The nard was a burial spice for his death. Jesus was readied for burial as he approached the hour of glorification and death (see study note on 12:23).

John 12:8

Jesus would not ignore the poor. He cared deeply for people in need.

However, this moment to honor and serve him was unique. It was a special opportunity that would not happen again.

John 12:12

- The next day was Sunday (see 12:1).
- A large crowd of religious travelers, many from Galilee, camped in this area. As Jesus traveled the road to Jerusalem, they cheered for him. This triumphal entry appears in all four Gospels (Matthew 21:1–11; Mark 11:1–11; Luke 19:29–38).

John 12:13

- Palm branches: The date palm symbolized pride in the Jewish nation and celebration.
- meet Him: The Greek word often describes crowds welcoming a king returning in triumph from a war.
- Blessed is He: The crowd quoted Psalm 118:25–26, with a greeting for those who came to Jerusalem.

The phrase "Blessed is the King of Israel!" is not in the psalm (but see Zephaniah 3:15). Although the people saw Jesus as a national political liberator, he rejected this role (John 6:15).

John 12:14

By choosing a young donkey instead of a warhorse, Jesus calmed the excited crowd that was eager for him to become king. He also fulfilled Old Testament prophecies about the Messiah (see Zechariah 9:9). He made it clear that his kingship was not based on violence. He did not come as a warrior to conquer nations. He came to give life. His rule would bring peace, not military victory.

John 12:16

The crowds did not fully understand who Jesus was. Even his disciples did not grasp the full meaning of what was happening. They saw the events, but they did not yet understand their true significance (their deeper meaning).

After Jesus was glorified (raised up in death, resurrection, and return to the Father), things changed. When the disciples received the Holy Spirit, they began to understand more clearly (see 2:22).

John 12:17–19

This scene describes the highest point of the popularity of Jesus. At this time, large crowds followed him. Many people were excited about his teaching and his miracles.

John 12:19

the whole world (literally the world): The Pharisees' words were more meaningful than they realized. Jesus came to reach the world (3:17), and the Pharisees said that Jesus had accomplished his task.

John 12:20

Among those people attracted to Jesus were some Greeks who believed in Israel's God. They had come to the Passover feast to worship (12:19). The mission of Jesus was not only for Israel but for the entire world (10:16; 11:52). After the resurrection of Jesus, the church's mission was to go beyond Judea to Samaria, and even to the ends of the earth (Matthew 28:19; Acts 1:8).

John 12:21

The Greeks approached Philip because he had a Greek name and was most likely also Greek.

John 12:23

Jesus often said that the hour had not yet come (2:4; 7:30; 8:20), but now it had. The arrival of the Greeks marked the beginning of the most important moment in the ministry of Jesus. This was the time of his glorification.

This happened when the saving work of Jesus on the cross was completed. He rose from the dead, gave the Holy Spirit, and returned to his place of glory in heaven (19:30; 20:1–31; 20:22; 17:5, 11).

The connection with the Greeks who had come to Jerusalem was important (12:20). The public ministry of Jesus among the Jews was coming to an end. His mission was not limited to one nation. Through his death and resurrection, he would belong to the whole world.

John 12:24

The central event of the glorification of Jesus was the cross (12:23). Like a kernel of wheat planted in the soil, the death of Jesus would bring abundant life.

John 12:25

For disciples (followers of Jesus), sacrifice and self-effacement (choosing not to put oneself first) are part of this path. They do not lose life by following Jesus. Instead, they gain the fullness of life that comes through his sacrifice.

Those who renounce (turn away from) the world's priorities will be with Jesus forever. God will honor those who serve his Son. In this way, the path of humble obedience leads to eternal life and honor.

John 12:27

My soul is troubled: John used the same term (Greek tarassō) to describe the strong emotion of agony that Jesus felt when he stood before Lazarus's tomb (11:33; also 13:21).

When Jesus faced his coming death, he was not without emotion. He did not act as if nothing troubled him. He experienced real anguish (deep sorrow and distress). Even in his distress, Jesus remained obedient to the Father's will. Throughout his ministry, he had said that he did only what the Father sent him to do (5:19–23; 6:37; 8:29, 38; 14:31).

John 12:28

- A voice came from heaven: Compare Matthew 3:17; 17:5; Mark 1:11; 9:7; Luke 3:22; 9:35.
- God had already brought glory to himself when Christ entered the world, and through the work of Jesus. This showed God's power to the world (John 1:14).
- I will glorify it again: The final display of glory would come at the cross (see 12:23; 17:1). In John's Gospel, the cross is an event of glory as Christ was "lifted up" and glorified there (12:32).

Jesus was prepared for crucifixion like a king coming to his coronation. The cross was like a throne (see 19:19–22). They buried Jesus like a king.

- The time of his glorification included all the events from his arrest through his resurrection.

John 12:29

It was impossible for people to comprehend what was happening with Jesus, and many of his signs led to confusion and division in the crowd. Only later did his disciples understand (2:22; 12:16), when Jesus was glorified and the Spirit was given. Still, God's voice symbolized his validation of his Son before the world.

John 12:31–33

- In John's Gospel, judgment does not happen only on the final Judgment Day. It began when Jesus came into the world as the light (3:19; 5:24; 9:39).
- Satan is the prince of this world. Satan promotes darkness, leads people into sin, and spreads death. Although Satan's final defeat is still future, his power was broken through the work of Jesus (see Luke 10:17–18; Mark 3:27).

Now Christ reigns as king in heaven (Acts 7:55–56; Ephesians 1:19–22).

John 12:32–34

when I am lifted up from the earth (see 3:14; 8:28): The crowd did not understand what Jesus meant. The Greek verb can also mean "be exalted" (Matthew 23:12). Or, it can refer to honor (Luke 10:15). In John's Gospel, the cross was not a place of shame for Jesus, but where his true glory was shown.

John 12:34

- Many people in the time of Jesus believed that the Messiah would live forever and defeat his enemies. They expected a strong and victorious ruler.

Because of this belief, the words Jesus spoke confused them.

- Who is this Son of Man?: The Jews did not understand what sort of Messiah planned to die.

John 12:36

- Jesus was the Light (1:4, 7–9; 3:19–21; 8:12). He urged the crowd to choose to believe in him before it was too late.
- They could become sons of the light by being spiritually born through God's power (1:12–13).
- was hidden from them: He first withdrew from Judea and then from this audience (11:54; 12:36). Soon, he would withdraw from the world (17:11).

John 12:37

Jesus finished his work, but they still did not believe in him. His sermons before the world were complete and the signs had been displayed, but he was rejected (1:11).

John 12:39–40

they were unable to believe: John quotes Isaiah 6:10 to explain Israel's lack of belief (see Matthew 13:13–15; Mark 4:12; Luke 8:10; Acts 28:26–27). When God's revelation comes, we must believe. If we refuse, the light disappears (John 12:35–36). When God's light departs, the darkness closes over unbelieving hearts. This means that continued rejection leads to deeper spiritual blindness.

John 12:41

The prophet Isaiah had seen the glory of the Messiah and how the world would respond (see Isaiah 6:10).

John 12:42–43

Many people did believe in Jesus. However, they were afraid to admit it in public.

They feared the reaction of the religious leaders and the social consequences that might follow.

To follow Jesus means more than private belief. It includes openly identifying with him and telling others about him, even when this may bring rejection (1:35–51; 4:1–42).

John 12:44–50

Jesus makes a final appeal for faith in him. These verses summarize chapters 1–12. The Father sent Jesus, who is the only source of his ministry. Jesus is the light shining in darkness to bring salvation and eternal life to all who believe in him.

John 12:49–50

The greatest error is for people to see the light and reject it, thinking it has no connection with the Father who sent the light.

John 13:1–38

The setting is the final Passover meal of Jesus on Thursday evening. During this meal, Judas Iscariot betrays Jesus. John does not describe the meal itself like the Synoptic Gospels do (Matthew 26:17–29; Mark 14:12–25; Luke 22:7–20; see also 1 Corinthians 11:23–26). John focuses on other activities at the event, such as:

- the foot washing (John 13:1–17),
- Judas's betrayal (13:18–30), and
- the prediction of Peter's denials (13:31–38).

John 13:1–20.31

This section focuses on the sign of the cross, the great climax of the life of Jesus, as well as the time Jesus spent preparing his disciples for it (chapters 13–17). Each event during these important days glorified Jesus. His arrest, trial, death on the cross, and resurrection all bring forth responses of awe. On the cross, Jesus is "lifted up" in glory before the world (12:32).

John 13:2

Judas ... Iscariot: He had refused to trust in Jesus. Darkness consumed him and he became a tool of the devil (compare study note on 12:39–40).

John 13:4–5

Foot washing was common in Greek and Jewish cultures as a daily routine. It was also a common gesture when hosting guests (see Luke 7:36–50). It was a humble task designated for servants. When Jesus began to wash the disciples' feet, he assumed the role of a servant.

John 13:8

Knowing how committed Peter was to Jesus, it makes sense that he protested. However, Jesus was not just showing Peter how to serve. This was a symbolic introduction of the greater sacrifice Jesus would make on the cross (13:7). Receiving spiritual cleansing from Jesus is necessary for discipleship. If Peter could not accept this act, he could not be a disciple of Jesus.

John 13:9

my hands and my head as well: Peter misunderstood Jesus (compare 2:19–20; 3:3–4). Peter thought having more water meant having more of Jesus. Everything became obvious to Peter only when he received the Holy Spirit (for example, see Acts 2:14–36).

John 13:10

Jesus was pointing to a deeper cleansing through his sacrifice.

He was not speaking only about washing the body. He was speaking about being made clean in a complete way.

Through his death, he makes a person clean all over. This means forgiveness of sin and a restored relationship with God.

John 13:14–15

- Jesus performed acts of humble service, such as washing his disciples' feet and giving his life on the cross. By doing this, he set an example for others to follow. He showed that true greatness is expressed through love, service, and personal sacrifice for others.
- wash one another's feet: Foot washing was a common act in that culture. Because of this, some think that Jesus meant for his followers to repeat this action in a literal way. Others believe he used it as a symbol of humble service.

In either case, the main point is clear. Jesus wants his followers to serve others with humility and self-giving love. Servanthood and sacrifice should mark their lives.

John 13:16

no servant is greater than his master: This saying was popular and appears in a number of passages (see also 15:20; Matthew 10:24; Luke 6:40). Here, Jesus meant that the servant should follow the master's example of sacrifice.

John 13:18

- I am not speaking about all of you: This is the third time Jesus mentions that Judas will betray him (13:2, 11). This matter deeply "troubled" Jesus (13:21).
- I know whom I have chosen: This does not mean Jesus only chose the 11 disciples and excluded Judas. Jesus chose Judas and gave him every opportunity to believe. He realized that Judas had chosen the darkness instead of the light (6:70).
- The one who shares My bread has lifted up his heel against Me: Eating together was a cultural symbol of personal intimacy, which made Judas's betrayal all the more serious.

John 13:19

- Judas's betrayal did not surprise Jesus. It should also not surprise his disciples when it happens.
- that I am He: By using the phrase I am, Jesus clearly identified himself with the God of the Old Testament. See Exodus 3:14.

John 13:21

For the third time in the Gospel of John, Jesus became troubled (Greek tarassō; see 11:33; 12:27). When Judas betrayed Jesus, it caused him deep grief.

John 13:23

- The disciple whom Jesus loved is appears:
- at the cross (19:26–27),
- at the tomb (20:2–9), and
- and at the resurrection (21:1, 20–23).

He also wrote the Gospel of John (21:24–25). Some scholars believe that Lazarus was in fact the disciple whom Jesus loved (see 11:3, 5, 36). The person referred to here was among the 12 apostles, so most people identify the disciple whom Jesus loved as the apostle John.

- was reclining at His side: They were likely reclining at a triclinium, a U-shaped table with couches around it. Guests reclined on the couches, while the center allowed those serving to access them. Those who were eating supported themselves with their left elbows and used their right hands to eat. They extended their feet away from the table (compare Luke 7:38).

John 13:25

Peter told the disciple sitting next to Jesus ("the one whom Jesus loved") to ask who would betray him (13:23). As the disciple was reclining next to Jesus, he leaned over and spoke to Jesus in private.

John 13:26

Meals included flat bread, which those eating would dip into a shared bowl. Jesus gave a piece to Judas (compare Ruth 2:14). The disciples might have thought Jesus was honoring him.

They did not understand what was happening. They even thought that when Judas left, it was to fulfill an official duty for the feast (John 13:29). However, Jesus was signaling to Judas that he knew Judas's plan and was not surprised. The knowledge Jesus has is deep and complete (see 1:48; 2:25).

John 13:27

- Satan entered into him: Judas became an example of what happens to people consumed by the dark-

ness (see Luke 22:3). Satan uses such people as tools in a wider struggle against the light.
- What you are about to do, do quickly: By giving this command, Jesus again showed he was in control, not human beings or Satan (see study note on John 7:30).

John 13:28–29

None of the others suspected that something odd was happening. Passover evening was one of the only nights when the city gates were left open. The night was spent in prayer and meditation, money was given to the poor, and provisions were always needed for this complex meal.

John 13:30

out into the night: This detail is more than a note about the time of day. It has symbolic meaning.

Judas's departure shows his spiritual condition. Darkness had taken hold of him completely (see study note on 13:2; compare 3:19). Jesus, the light of the world, is the opposite of the night.

John 13:31

The time had come. Judas's departure into the night marked a clear turning point in the story of the Gospel. Jesus was now left with his closest friends, as the hour of his glory was beginning. This period began with Judas's betrayal and ended with the resurrection.

John 13:31–17.26

The Old Testament and later Jewish literature include numerous examples of farewells in which a dying person offers last words to intimate friends (see Gen 49:1–27; Deut 31–34; Josh 23–24; 1 Sam 12; 1 Chr 28:1–29:30). Such farewells used a standard form. The dying person, surrounded by his loved ones, comforted them and exhorted them to obey the law. He prayed and blessed them and often left behind some writings. In some cases, the departing person passed on his "spirit" to his followers or his successor (see Num 27:18; Deut 34:9; 2 Kgs 2:9–14). Each of these elements is present in Jesus' farewell. • This section is often called the Upper Room Discourse, since the meal was taken in an "upstairs room" (Luke 22:12).

John 13:33

Jesus addressed the apostles as his children, marking the start of his farewell address.

John 13:34–35

The command for the disciples to love one another was not new (see Leviticus 19:18). However, loving each other as Jesus loved was a dramatic change. Jesus showed his love for God through perfect obedience (John 14:31). Now, he commanded that disciples show their love for him through committed obedience.

John 13:37

Peter claimed to be ready to die for Jesus. But Peter is well known for denying Jesus (18:15–18, 25–27; see also Matthew 26:32–34; Mark 14:27–30; Luke 22:31–34). Although Peter's courage and loyalty failed, Jesus forgave and restored him (John 21:15–19).

John 14:1

- Jesus felt troubled (Greek tarassō) on three occasions (11:33; 12:27; 13:21). His trust in God's power helped him confront these difficult times. When the disciples heard the upsetting words of 13:33, they felt the same way.
- believe (or trust, or have faith) in God: Only trusting God would help them through his hour of death.

John 14:1–31

Jesus provided answers to his disciples' many spoken and unspoken concerns.

John 14:2

In My Father's house are many rooms: God's house is where he lives (Revelation 21:9–22:5). The Greek word for rooms comes from a verb meaning "remain, abide, dwell." Jesus promises his followers a place to live with him, wherever he is. Later, this house becomes a spiritual presence. Jesus makes his home in the hearts of his followers through the Holy Spirit (John 14:23). This means that believers carry God's presence inside them.

John 14:3

Some scholars think that Jesus meant he would come and get his followers after the resurrection (14:18). Others think these words refer to the second coming of Jesus. For the disciples, the return of Jesus from the grave was more important (chapter 16).

John 14:6

- I am: See study note on 6:35. You can only access the Father through Jesus, who is the way and the truth and the life.

- The way to the Father is only through Jesus. Other religions and philosophies suggest different ways to God. But Jesus claimed he is the only way to God.
- Jesus is the truth because God is truth.
- God is the source of eternal life. At Lazarus's tomb, Jesus demonstrated his divine power over life and death (11:25).

John 14:8

Philip did not yet understand that in Jesus he was seeing the full embodiment of God (14:9).

John 14:9

Anyone who has seen Me has seen the Father: Compare 1:1–2. Jesus Christ is God in human body (1:14). This explains his ability to perform divine works. Jesus did not just teach about God, he is God. Jesus's remarkable statement here echoed what he said at the Feast of Dedication (Hanukkah): "I and the Father are one" (10:30). This claim is the reason for the world's opposition to Christ (5:18).

John 14:10

Jesus made surprising and powerful claims about himself (10:30, 37–38). However, true faith recognizes the close union between Jesus and God the Father. To believe in Jesus is to trust that he truly reveals and represents the Father.

John 14:12

- Jesus promised that those who believe in him would do great works and pray with confidence (see 1 John 5:14). This would happen after Jesus returned to the Father, when he sent the Holy Spirit to give them strength and guidance (John 14:16).
- The greater things will not surpass what Jesus did. Instead, ordinary people will do these works because the Holy Spirit gives them power. God promised that in the era of the Spirit, he would bring his kingdom and power into the world in a new way.

John 14:15

If you love me: Because Jesus loves the Father, he is obedient to what God directs him to say and do (12:49). If we love him, we will obey him, too (14:21, 23; 15:10, 14; see 1 John 2:3–4; 5:2).

John 14:16

another Advocate: The Spirit continues the work of Jesus by advising, defending, and protecting believers.

John 14:17

the Spirit of truth: The Holy Spirit communicates the truth about God (see also 15:26; 16:13). The Spirit maintains the presence of Jesus in the world, continuing and supporting the work Jesus began.

John 14:18

Jesus had already assured his followers that they would not be spiritual orphans and that he would return to them (14:1–4). While he is away, they will be filled with the Spirit, who will sustain them with his presence (14:12–17).

John 14:20

The resurrection of Jesus began a new spiritual union with his disciples (14:19). This union is like the close relationship he has with the Father (see 15:4–5; 1 John 1:3).

John 14:22

- Several men named Judas appear in the New Testament. Judas, the brother of Jesus, wrote the letter of Jude (Mark 6:3). Luke 6:16 lists Judas, the son of James, as a disciple (John mentions this Judas in this verse). He is also known as Thaddaeus (Matthew 10:3; Mark 3:18).
- Lord, why: Judas asked an important question. If Jesus planned to return powerfully from death, why not use the chance to show himself plainly to the world? Why not prove his power and identity?

John 14:23–24

- Jesus answered Judas's question. He said his coming would be a deep spiritual revelation that the world would not understand.
- The coming of Jesus would happen in three events:
- his resurrection,
- the arrival of the Holy Spirit, and
- his second coming.

When he comes through the Spirit, he and the Father will live within Christians, making a home with each of them (see study note on 14:2).

John 14:26

- Jesus promised to send the Holy Spirit (see also 14:16; 15:26; 16:7, 12–14).
- The Holy Spirit ... will teach you all things: The Holy Spirit will teach the disciples everything. He will help them remember the words of Jesus and understand what those words mean. John experienced this help from the Spirit as he wrote his gospel

(2:22). Christians also experience this work of the Spirit as they hear and study the Scriptures.

John 14:27

The Jewish greeting peace (Hebrew shalom) shows the goal of the work of Jesus on earth: to restore humanity's relationship with God (Isaiah 9:6–7; 52:7; 57:19; Romans 5:1). The resurrection and the coming of the Holy Spirit helped complete this work (John 14:28).

John 14:28

The Father is greater than I am: See also 5:19–20. Jesus is submissive to the Father but is also one with the Father (10:30).

John 14:30

the prince of this world: Satan did not control the events in Jerusalem that led to the cross. The death of Jesus on the cross was not an accident, and Jesus was not a helpless victim. Instead, Jesus obeyed God's plan.

John 15:1

I am: See study note on 6:35. The vine and the vineyard have traditionally represented God's people. He "plants and tends" them in Israel (Psalm 80:8–18; Isaiah 5:1–7; Jeremiah 2:21; 12:10–11; Ezekiel 15:1–5; Hosea 10:1–2). When Jesus used this image, he made an important change. He declared that he is the true vine and that a relationship with God requires attachment to him.

John 15:1–27

Jesus prepared his disciples for his departure, instructing them to remain in close fellowship with him. The image of a grapevine illustrates both intimacy and fruitfulness. To sustain genuine spiritual life in the world, believers must remain intimately connected to Christ.

John 15:2–3

Gardeners cut away dead branches and trim healthy branches so they will produce more fruit. Fruitfulness is the result of life-giving connection to the vine.

John 15:4

The term remain (Greek menō) is important for understanding 15:4–10. A growing disciple, in whom the Father and the Son live through the Spirit, must be continuously connected to Christ (see 14:16–25; 15:26).

John 15:6

\Anyone who does not remain in Christ is separated from the vine and its life. A living branch produces clusters of grapes (15:5). Connection with the vine allows the life of Jesus to flow fruitfully through the disciple. Those who claim to be attached to Christ but yield no fruit are useless and will be burned.

John 15:7

Those whose lives are in harmony with Jesus may ask for anything because their prayers are controlled by his word. Their prayers will be answered and bring glory to God (14:10–13).

John 15:8

True disciples will experience a transformed, fruit-bearing life because they live in a relationship of love with both Jesus and the Father (15:9–10).

John 15:10

Just as Jesus demonstrated his love for the Father by obeying his will (14:31), the disciples of Jesus show their love by obeying him (13:34–35; 14:15; 1 John 2:5; 5:2–3).

John 15:12–13

- This is My commandment ... love each other: See 13:34.
- Jesus demonstrated his love by sacrificing his life at the cross.

John 15:14–16

God considered Abraham and Moses to be his friends (Exodus 33:11; 2 Chronicles 20:7; Isaiah 41:8; James 2:23). This is the closest relationship possible between God and a person. Jesus chooses his friends (John 15:16). They demonstrate their friendship by obeying him.

John 15:15

The disciples of a rabbi were considered his servants or slaves. Jesus elevated his followers to a higher relationship as his friends.

John 15:18–27

Disciples must be like their master in every way. They must show love and obedience and experience opposition from those against their message (15:20–21; see 9:1–41; 11:16). Darkness opposes light (1:5). The followers of Jesus carry that light in the world (1 John 1:7; 2:9). They should expect the world to hate them in

the way it hated Jesus (see John 17:14). The disciples of Jesus share his separation from and conflict with the world.

John 15:20

No servant is greater than his master: See study note on 13:16. The disciples of Jesus should live like him in every way, even when they face suffering or death because of their faith.

John 15:22–24

Now, however, they have no excuse: The ministry of Jesus provided both words and works as evidence that pointed to God (15:22; 15:24). Once people have heard and seen him, they are accountable.

John 15:25

They hated Me without reason: This Old Testament citation shows the unjustified anger of people who live in the darkness, meaning those who oppose God's truth.

John 15:26

When the Advocate comes, whom I will send to you from the Father—the Spirit of truth: Like a legal representative, the Holy Spirit is counselor and protector of the followers of Jesus.

John 15:27

Disciples are not alone when they testify about Christ (Matthew 28:20). The Holy Spirit is with them and gives them the words to say (Matthew 10:19–20).

John 16:1–2

Jesus had described the coming conflicts so the disciples would not abandon their faith (literally be caused to stumble (15:18–25). The biggest challenge they would encounter was rejecting their faith in front of their opponents (see Matthew 23:34; Luke 6:22). This would especially be true during the difficult times ahead (see John 12:35; 1 John 2:9–11).

John 16:7

the Advocate: This title refers to the Holy Spirit. The word can mean helper, comforter, or one who speaks on behalf of another.

Jesus taught that the Spirit would come after his departure and glorification (his death, resurrection, and return to the Father; see 7:37–39; 14:16, 26; 15:26; 16:12–14).

The Spirit was a promised gift. After Jesus returned to the Father, the Spirit would guide, teach, and strengthen his followers.

John 16:8

The Holy Spirit unveils to the world:

- the real nature of its sin,
- the truth about righteousness found only in God, and
- the coming judgment.

In one sense, this judgment has already begun. When God's light shines into the darkness, it exposes what is wrong and calls people to respond.

John 16:8–11

One of the Spirit's roles is to convict the world. Convict is a legal term: The world had conducted its trial of Jesus, examining the evidence for his case (his signs and claims). Now the world would stand trial before the Spirit, and its guilt would be proven.

John 16:11

The judgment of sinners had already started. This was because God had already judged the prince of this world, Satan (see 12:31). The world believed it was judging Jesus, but the opposite was true.

John 16:13

- The Spirit of truth, who brings truth from God, guides the judgment of the world.
- The Spirit speaks only what he hears from the Father. The Father, Son, and Spirit work in perfect unity (16:15). The disciples could expect the Spirit to reveal new things about the present and future (see 14:26).

John 16:16

Jesus reassured the disciples that his departure (on the cross) would be short and his return (in the resurrection) would be soon. When they saw him again, the disciples would experience overwhelming joy and intimacy with him in the Spirit.

John 16:16–33

a little while: Jesus repeated this phrase to comfort his disciples. He wanted them to know that their separation from him would not last long. Although he would soon leave them, he would return to them again.

John 16:20

With the death of Jesus on the cross, the world thought it had won a victory over the light. The sur-

prise of the cross would cause the disciples to weep and mourn, but their sorrow would change to joy when Jesus defeated the grave (20:20).

John 16:21

pain in childbirth: This metaphor symbolizes anguish that is followed by God's blessing and wonder (compare Isaiah 21:2–3; 26:16–21; 66:7–10; Jeremiah 13:21).

John 16:23–24

Ask and you will receive: Two notable effects of the resurrection are the joy of understanding and the joy of successful prayer. The disciples would no longer experience the confusion described in 16:16–18.

John 16:25

Jesus spoke using figures of speech, which could only be interpreted with God's help (1 Corinthians 1:18–25). With the coming of the Holy Spirit, the disciples would understand.

John 16:26–27

After the resurrection of Jesus, the Holy Spirit brought a close relationship with God. Through the Spirit, disciples could live in God's presence and speak to the Father about their needs (14:23).

John 16:33

take courage; I have overcome the world!: "Such a saying as this is worthy to be carried from Rome to Jerusalem on one's knees" (Martin Luther). The final words of Jesus did not rebuke his disciples. Instead, he spoke to comfort them. Jesus promised peace and joy (14:27; 16:20, 22).

Now he added that his disciples can discover peace even when surrounded by threats. They can remain calm even when others oppose their faith.

John 17:1

- Jesus looked up to heaven. This was the traditional Jewish way to pray (11:41; Psalm 123:1). He probably also raised his hands (Exodus 9:33; 17:11; Psalm 28:2). Jesus said prayers like this out loud so his followers could hear them (John 11:41–42; 12:27–30; also Matthew 11:25–30; Luke 10:21–22).
- Father was the usual way Jesus addressed God, which he did six times in this prayer (see also John 11:41; 12:27). This title, uncommon in the Jewish faith, showed the intimate relationship Jesus has with God.
- the hour: This hour included the betrayal of Jesus by Judas, his arrest, torture, death, and resurrection (see study note on 12:23).
- Glorify your Son: In the Gospel of John, the cross is a place of honor. The unity of Jesus with the Father means that if the Son receives glory, the Father will also receive glory.

John 17:1–26

This chapter contains the longest prayer of Jesus. People often refer to it as the "high priestly prayer." The prayer shows the deepest concerns and purposes of Jesus.

This prayer concludes his last words that began at 13:31. Jesus expressed his own concerns to his Father (17:1–8). He then expressed concerns for the church and its future (17:9–26).

John 17:2

All authority has been placed in Jesus' hands (3:35); he can give eternal life as only God can (3:15; 5:21, 25–26).

John 17:3

- that they may know you: In the Hebrew language, "knowing" includes experience and intimacy. For Christians, this means loving God and obeying him.
- whom You have sent: Jesus came from heaven and was returning (John 17:5). So he has divine authority as God's agent.

John 17:4

The miracles of Jesus displayed God's glory to the world (1:14). This task was finished. The life and obedience of Jesus glorified God.

John 17:5

Jesus prayed to return to the position he had with God before the world began (1:1).

John 17:6

This verse summarizes what Jesus came to do. He revealed the true person of God to the world, gathered up God's people into his flock, and instructed them in obedience. The result of this work is the church.

John 17:8

Jesus revealed himself to the world. Those who received his message became children of God (1:12; 11:52). He revealed God's word to them.

John 17:9–19

Jesus prayed for his disciples, who must continue his work after his departure.

John 17:10

Just as the Son brings glory to the Father (17:1, 4–5), the disciples bring the Son glory (17:22). The love and obedience that brought glory to God in the life of Jesus become features of his disciples' lives.

John 17:11

The first concern Jesus had for his disciples was that they would remain united with each other in the same way he is one with the Father.

John 17:12–13

Until now, Jesus had guarded his followers. Now he was concerned for their strength and survival in his absence, because the world would be hostile toward them and their mission of challenging the world by preaching the truth (15:18–27; 16:8–11). After Jesus departed to heaven, the Holy Spirit would protect them and bring them joy (15:26).

John 17:14

God's word, which Jesus had given his disciples, also provides a defense against the world. The Spirit would preserve and recall God's word in the church (14:26), equipping the church for its encounter with the world.

John 17:16–18

Sanctify: This refers to purity gained by separation from the world, and living a life so aligned with God that it reflects Disciples are set apart by God, equipped by the Spirit, and prepared by God's word to enter the world without being victimized by its darkness.

John 17:19

I sanctify Myself: Priests and prophets were similarly set apart for service to God (Leviticus 8:30; Jeremiah 1:5). Jesus again committed himself to God's mission. He recognized that he was set apart for the purpose of the cross. The disciples would benefit because his death would enable them to experience new holiness in a deep attachment to God.

John 17:20

Jesus was praying for other sheep who were not yet in his flock (10:16). These are the believers through the centuries who have come to faith through the witness of the disciples of Jesus.

John 17:21

- Be one: For believers, becoming one with one another is an outgrowth of the union they enjoy with Jesus himself, a union modeled on the oneness of the Father and the Son.
- May they also be in Us: Through the Holy Spirit's power, believers experience a profound and intimate union with the Father and the Son, leading to transformation (14:20, 23; 1 John 4:13).
- Disciples of Jesus represent him, so their right actions and relationships with each other reflect the credibility of Christ in the world. When there is disunity, infighting, and intolerance, their testimony to the world is unconvincing. When people observe the community of believers, they know that it represents Jesus; a unified, loving community convinces the world to believe (John 13:35; 1 John 3:11).

John 17:22

The community of believers should display the same glory that Jesus displayed from the Father.

John 17:23

so that the world may know: If the church lives in the Spirit, reflects God's glory and love, and shows unity sustained by a shared knowledge of God, then its testimony will amaze the world.

John 17:24

I want those You have given Me to be with Me: Someday, all the followers of Jesus will see his true glory and the love that has existed in heaven before the beginning of time (17:5). Jesus was returning to heaven and deeply wanted to see his disciples there so that they might witness what words on earth cannot describe.

John 17:26

- All who accept the Son and embrace the Father will experience the kind of love known only between the Father and the Son.
- I in them: Jesus loves his followers and wants to fill them with glory and joy that compares to nothing in the world.

John 18:1–2

- Jesus crossed the Kidron Valley. This was a dry river valley (a wadi) outside the eastern walls of Jerusalem.
- a garden: This is the Garden of Gethsemane (Mark 14:32). This garden was a group of olive trees on the west side of the Mount of Olives. The Aramaic name

gath shemaney means "olive press." Jesus liked this place and often prayed there (see John 8:1; Luke 21:37; 22:39).

John 18:1–40

Jesus finished speaking his final words to his disciples in the upper room (13:31–17:26). Jesus then left the city and went to a garden east of Jerusalem to pray. There, authorities arrested him and took him back into the city for questioning by the Jewish religious leaders. The important "hour" Jesus often mentioned throughout the Gospel had arrived (see 2:4; see also study note on 12:23).

John 18:3

John's full account of the group that arrested him adds details not mentioned in the other Gospels. The temple authorities sent Roman soldiers and temple guards. While the temple guards arrested Jesus, the Roman soldiers stood by to prevent a riot. The Roman group was large enough to need a commander. They came with weapons and were expecting a struggle (18:10, 12). Many people claimed to be the Messiah. Often, they tried to force the Romans out of the land, which caused political conflict.

John 18:5

I am He (literally I am): Jesus identified himself by the divine name God had revealed to Moses on Mount Sinai (see Exodus 3:14; see also John 4:26; 8:24, 58).

John 18:6

All the soldiers and guards fell back before the Lord (compare Isaiah 6:5; Ezekiel 1:28; Daniel 10:9; Acts 9:4; Revelation 1:17). Even the Roman soldiers, who were trained to stand firm, fell to the ground before Christ. They did this to show submission, but they did not fully understand what had happened and went on with the arrest.

John 18:8

I am He: Jesus used God's divine name for the second time (see study note on 18:5).

John 18:9

I have not lost one: Jesus continued to be a good shepherd, offering his life for the sheep and protecting them from the wolves (10:11–15). From the beginning, however, Judas Iscariot had not been a true disciple of Jesus (17:12).

John 18:10–11

- Simon Peter drew his sword: This was a short sword or long knife, usually worn with everyday clothes.
- The Hebrew name Malchus means "king." John may have included this detail as a subtle wordplay pointing to the true identity of Jesus (see 18:36–37; 19:19).
- Put your sword back: The mission of Jesus was not to fight for his life, but to die for ours.

John 18:12–14

- Soldiers bound Jesus and took him back to Jerusalem.
- First, they brought him to Annas, who had been the high priest and remained very influential. Five of his sons also became high priests. Caiaphas, his son-in-law, was the official high priest at that time (see 18:24).

John 18:14

one man died for the people: Caiaphas had said this as a political calculation (11:49–50). John points out the irony: the death of Jesus did not bring political freedom to Israel. Instead, it brought spiritual salvation for everyone who believes in him.

John 18:15

another disciple: The other disciple is not named but was probably "the one whom Jesus loved" (13:23). This disciple was the apostle John and the author of this book.

John 18:16–17

While Annas was questioning Jesus, the girl watching the door asked Peter if he was one of the disciples of Jesus (18:12–14, 19–24). Jesus confronted his questioners and denied nothing. But Peter quickly denied his connection to Jesus three times (18:17, 25, 27).

John 18:19

The high priest asked Jesus questions, which went against Jewish legal procedures. In Jewish court, the priest did not directly question the person on the defense. Instead, they gathered evidence from witnesses to prove guilt (see Numbers 35:30; Deuteronomy 17:6; 19:15; compare Matthew 18:16). If Jesus said anything that would make him guilty, Annas would use it against him at his trial. Annas tried to follow Roman practice by making Jesus say something about himself that would make him guilty. This was different than using witnesses as Jewish law required.

John 18:20–21

Jesus's direct response reminded Annas that everything was public knowledge. This exposed the priest's attempt to follow Roman practice.

John 18:22–23

When Jesus reminded Annas about the correct legal procedure, one of the temple guards thought he was being disrespectful. The guard slapped Jesus.

However, Jesus knew the law well and spoke truthfully. There were no witnesses accusing him, and no evidence was presented against him.

John 18:24

Annas could say no more. His questioning had failed. So he sent Jesus to Caiaphas to be tried before the Sanhedrin, Jerusalem's judicial high council (see Mark 14:53–15:1).

John 18:25–27

He denied it: Peter denied knowing Jesus three times. Later, Jesus asked Peter three times to reaffirm his love (21:15–17).

John 18:28

- The trial before Caiaphas ended in the early hours of the morning. The Sanhedrin (Jewish high council) did not have the power to execute someone. They needed Pilate, the Roman governor, to carry out an execution (18:31).
- They did not want to become ritually unclean by contact with Gentiles in Pilate's headquarters. So Pilate, probably fearing a riot, went outside to meet them.
- The Passover meal itself had taken place the night before (see 13:1; Mark 14:14–16). The next day, another meal began the week-long Feast of Unleavened Bread (Leviticus 23:5–6).

John 18:29

Pilate, the fifth Roman governor of Judea, ruled the country from AD 26 to 36. He usually lived on the coast in Caesarea, but kept troops stationed in a fortress in Jerusalem where he appeared personally for major festivals. He was a brutal ruler whose atrocities against the Jews were legendary (for example, Luke 13:1; Josephus, War 2.9.2–4).

John 18:31–32

Pilate did not consider the charges convincing. So he told the Sanhedrin to judge Jesus by their own law. Pilate saw this as a Jewish argument, which he refused to investigate.

However, the Jewish leaders insisted that execution was necessary. This fulfilled the prediction Jesus made about how he would die (see 12:32–33). The Jews would have used stoning, but the Romans used crucifixion. If Pilate sentenced Jesus, the Romans would hang Jesus on a cross to die.

John 18:33

- Pilate was personally responsible for capital crimes in which the interests and security of the Roman Empire were at stake, so he began his formal legal inquiry.
- Are You the King of the Jews?: To get the governor's attention, Caiaphas accused Jesus of telling people not to pay taxes to Rome and claiming to be a king (Luke 23:2). To Pilate, Jesus might have seemed like another Jewish terrorist or revolutionary with ideas about the Messiah and a group of armed followers (see Luke 23:18–19; Acts 5:36–37).

John 18:34–35

The response Jesus gave forced the governor to reveal the origin of his question. The temple leaders were responsible for these accusations. Pilate only wanted to know if Jesus was a rebel who might threaten Roman interests.

John 18:36–37

Jesus was willing to accept the title of king, but he made it clear that he did not govern an earthly kingdom that might rival Rome. The kingship of Jesus is not of this world. Rather than being a political ruler, he rules through the devotion and obedience of his followers.

John 18:38–39

- What is truth?: Truth was not a foreign idea to Pilate. But he did not wait for an answer because he did not believe there was one.
- Pilate returned to the council members waiting outside and delivered his verdict: not guilty. Although he referred to Jesus as "King of the Jews" (see also 19:19), the title was just an expression meant to mock Jesus. Pilate wanted to release Jesus. His offer showed that he did not want Jesus to be executed.

John 18:40

Jesus was not a threat to Rome, but Barabbas was a revolutionary. He was a violent man involved in political uprisings. Barabbas had proven his capacity

to challenge the Roman military occupation of Israel (see Luke 23:19).

John 19:1–16

Pilate had Jesus beaten after his sentencing (Mark 15:15). However, John here describes an earlier beating. This was likely Pilate's attempt to show that Jesus had been punished and he could release him (John 19:4). When this failed, Pilate passed his sentence and handed Jesus over to the Jewish leaders for crucifixion (19:16).

John 19:2

- The crown of thorns might have come from a date palm tree (compare 12:13–14). There are Greek coin images showing such crowns, with the stems woven and the thorns radiating upward above the crown.
- The purple robe was probably a soldier's robe. It was dark red, completing the picture of mock royalty.

John 19:4–6

- Pilate wanted to show Jesus to the crowd, hoping they would see his injuries and agree to release him. After being beaten with a whip with lead tips, Jesus was bleeding heavily.
- Pilate again declared that Jesus was not guilty, but the crowd loudly demanded his death (19:6).

John 19:6

Pilate knew that a riot could happen when a man popular with the masses was executed, so he shifted responsibility to crucify Jesus to the temple leaders.

John 19:7

- During the trial before Caiaphas, the charge of blasphemy (calling himself the Son of God) was determined to be the true crime Jesus had committed (see Mark 14:61–65).
- The leaders had already tried to set Jesus against Roman interests and they would do it again (John 18:33; 19:12). Now they challenged the governor in different way. Pilate had to maintain peace by enforcing local law, even if it did not matter to Rome. Claiming to be God's son was not illegal. Even Israel's kings did this (Psalms 2:7; 89:22–27). However, Jesus claimed to have God's divine authority, which they considered blasphemy (see John 5:18).

John 19:8–9

- Pilate … was even more afraid: Pilate was superstitious, and stories of gods appearing in the world were not uncommon (Acts 14:11). He sensed more than a political fight was happening, so he asked Jesus, "Where are you from?" Pilate was not asking where Jesus was born. He was asking if Jesus was a divine man who came down from heaven.
- Why Jesus did not answer is uncertain. Perhaps Pilate would not have understood that true power comes only from God, who had empowered Jesus (compare John 19:11).

John 19:10–11

You would have no authority over Me: Pilate had the power to crucify Jesus, but only because God gave him this temporary power. He allowed Pilate to have this power so that Jesus could advance toward the cross (see 10:18).

John 19:12

- Pilate tried to release Jesus each time they talked. Despite his efforts, he failed.
- friend of Caesar: This was an official title for those, like senators, who showed great loyalty to the Roman emperor. The Jewish religious leaders implied they would damage Pilate's career by claiming he did not support Rome's interests. They probably knew that Pilate was also having a personal crisis.

Pilate's patron in Rome, Sejanus, was the chief administrator of the empire under Tiberius Caesar. Sejanus had fallen from favor and was executed in AD 31. Pilate had every reason to be afraid.

John 19:13

- Pilate sat on the governor's judgment seat to give his verdict. In Greek, the word for this seat is bēma (compare Acts 25:6, "seat in court").
- The Stone Pavement was the platform for the judgment seat. From there, Pilate spoke with the authority of his office.

John 19:14

The day of Preparation for the Passover: Here, Passover refers to the entire Feast of Unleavened Bread, not just the Jewish Passover meal from the night before. It was Friday, the preparation day for the Passover Sabbath. The Sabbath would start when the sun set (compare Mark 15:42; Luke 23:54).

John 19:15

The final words of the priests, "We have no king but Caesar," are a contradiction of the Old Testament belief that God was Israel's king (compare Judges 8:23; 1 Samuel 8:7; 10:19). Jerusalem and its religious leaders

were killing their true king while honoring Caesar, the pagan king of Rome (John 18:37).

John 19:16

Pilate handed Jesus over to the Roman soldiers. They prepared him for crucifixion with a second flogging, which nearly killed him (Mark 15:15). Jesus bled heavily, and his clothes were soaked in blood. The crown of thorns pressed deeply into his head. Nearly in shock, the soldiers forced Jesus to march to a site outside the city.

John 19:17

- The vertical beam (Latin staticulum) of the cross usually stayed at the crucifixion site. The victim carried only the heavy cross beam (Latin patibulum).
- Crucifixions were public executions near major roads. The Romans designed them to shock and warn the people.
- The Place of the Skull (Hebrew and Aramaic Golgotha; Latin calvariae, "Calvary"): Most archaeologists agree that the crucifixion of Jesus happened at the site of the modern Church of the Holy Sepulchre. This is in the Christian Quarter of the old walled city of Jerusalem.

An alternative site, Gordon's Calvary (north of the Damascus Gate), shows what the scene might have looked like. However, it only has a tomb from the 500s BC, so it is unlikely to be where Jesus was crucified and buried.

John 19:18

None of the writers of the Gospels focus on the details of being nailed to the cross because people already knew it was horrible. The soldiers used the cross as a tool for torture. They wanted victims to live for a while, sometimes for days.

Because the Sabbath would begin when the sun set, they sped up the crucifixion of Jesus (19:31). Jesus had been severely beaten with whips tipped with stone or metal, so his back was deeply cut, and he was bleeding heavily.

John 19:19–22

Pilate posted a sign on the cross. Roman soldiers usually provided a written notice of the criminal's name and crimes. As a possible act of revenge against the Jewish high council, Pilate ordered the sign to identify Jesus of Nazareth as the King of the Jews. The sign was posted in three languages for the whole world to understand.

John 19:23–24

As was their common practice, the Roman soldiers divided his clothes. The soldiers gambled for his valuable robe, which was seamless, rather than dividing it up.

John 19:25–26

- This is the only reference to the sister of the mother of Jesus in the New Testament. She might have been the wife of Zebedee and the mother of James and John (compare Matthew 27:56). This would make Jesus and John cousins. If so, it would help explain why Jesus asked the disciple he loved (John) to care for Mary (John's aunt).
- This is the only place that mentions Mary, the wife of Clopas. She might be the same as Mary, the mother of James and Joseph (compare Matthew 27:56).
- Jesus healed Mary Magdalene, a woman from the village of Magdala (Mark 16:9; Luke 8:2).
- Woman was a respectful and polite way of speaking in that culture (see John 2:4).

John 19:27

Here is your mother: Jesus used a Jewish family law to assign one person's care to another. This scene had additional importance: The people present represented the new community of the church that was born at the cross. Jesus wanted them to care for each other, following his command to love one another (13:34; 15:12, 17).

John 19:29

In Egypt, people used the hyssop bush to apply lamb's blood on door posts and its upper threshold (lintel) during the first Passover (Exodus 12:22). Jesus is God's Passover lamb, and his blood also saves (John 1:29, 36).

John 19:30

Jesus called out in triumph and exhaustion that he had finished the work he set out to do. On the cross he was not a victim, but a servant doing God's bidding.

John 19:31–33

The Jewish authorities, eager to complete the crucifixion before Sabbath began at dusk, asked Pilate to break the legs of the men. It was common to break the legs of those crucified with a tool. It caused them to stop breathing and bleed excessively because the victim could not push themselves up to breathe.

John 19:34

- To confirm that Jesus was dead, a Roman soldier stabbed his side with a spear.
- blood and water flowed out: This has several levels of meaning:

1. The spear probably cut through the pericardium, the sack around the heart, releasing these fluids.
2. John might have been thinking of more Passover symbolism. The Passover lamb's blood had to flow as it died.
3. The water flowing from the side of Jesus is similar to the language of "living water" that Jesus had mentioned earlier (see 4:10–14; 7:37–39).

John 19:35

John stood at the foot of the cross (19:26). He did not just collect stories about Jesus. He witnessed the events and gave an accurate account of the life of Jesus (see 21:24). This same confidence is also evident in the opening words of John's first letter (1 John 1:1–4).

John 19:36

"Not one of His bones will be broken": God did not allow for the Passover lamb to have broken bones (Exodus 12:46; Numbers 9:12). Jesus was the final Passover lamb (compare Psalm 34:20; see also 1 Corinthians 5:7).

John 19:37

"They will look on the One they have pierced": Zechariah 12:10 describes how Israel would look on a prophet or the Messiah and lament their own tragic lack of faith.

John 19:38

- According to Luke's Gospel, Joseph of Arimathea was a brave man "waiting for the kingdom of God" (Luke 23:50–51). He was a wealthy and influential leader in Jerusalem and a member of the Jewish high council (Matthew 27:57; Mark 15:43). He disagreed with the decision to kill Jesus. He asked Pilate for permission to bury Jesus in his own tomb.
- Joseph was a secret disciple (compare John 12:42–43). But his bold action showed his public support for Jesus.

John 19:39

- Nicodemus (see 3:1; 7:50) was a member of the Jewish high council. He knew these bodies had to be buried before the Sabbath (19:31, 42). His public support, like that of Joseph of Arimathea, might show he was becoming a disciple (see study note on 7:49–51).
- Myrrh was a commonly used powder that smelled good.
- The aloes were fragrant powdered sandalwood often used as perfume.
- seventy-five pounds: This large amount of spices was fit for royalty. Jesus, the king, received a royal burial.

John 19:41

a new tomb: People have discovered more than 900 first-century burial tombs in Judea, carved into the limestone hills.

John 19:42

because it was the Jewish day of Preparation: See study note on 19:14. It was almost the Sabbath, so Joseph and Nicodemus planned to return later to finish the burial process (19:38–39).

John 20:1

- Mary Magdalene, a dedicated follower of Jesus, went to the tomb to help finish burying Jesus (see Matthew 27:55–56; Luke 8:1–3; see John 19:42).
- Many Judean tombs were sealed with a rolling stone.

John 20:2

Mary Magdalene ran to find Simon Peter. She assumed that someone had taken the body of Jesus from the tomb. This kind of tomb disturbance did happen in the ancient world.

John 20:3–10

The other disciple was likely John, "the one whom Jesus loved" and the author of this Gospel (see 13:23). He and Peter confirmed Mary's testimony by checking the tomb themselves. John got there first, but Peter went in first.

John 20:6–7

What Peter and John found in the tomb was remarkable. The linen cloths were on the burial bench (19:40). Jews also used a cloth on the face for burials. They rolled it, wrapped it under the chin, and tied it on top of the head (see 11:44). The apostles found this cloth folded on the bench. John included these details to counter any suggestion that grave robbers had taken the body of Jesus. Thieves would have taken such expensive clothes in a robbery.

John 20:8–9

he saw and believed: Even though he did not fully understand, John knew God had done this, and he realized Jesus was alive.

John 20:11–13

- Even though two angels appeared inside the tomb, it was still a mystery how Jesus disappeared (see Luke 24:4).
- Why are you weeping?: Sorrow was not the appropriate response in this moment.

John 20:14–15

Mary thought Jesus was the gardener. Jesus repeated the angel's question and asked, "Whom are you seeking?" Jesus wanted Mary to think. At this point Mary was looking for the body of Jesus, but she was about to meet the living Christ.

John 20:16

When Jesus called Mary by name, she recognized him immediately (see 10:3–4).

John 20:17

Mary thought that with the resurrection, Jesus would resume normal relations with his disciples. She was trying to cling to the joy she discovered in her resurrected Lord. But his fellowship with her would come in a new form (20:22). Jesus had not yet ascended to complete his return to the Father, but the process was underway. Before his final departure, he would give the Holy Spirit (20:22; see 14:15–21, 26; 15:26–27; 16:5–15).

John 20:18

Mary was the first person to see the Lord after his resurrection. She not only saw him, but also heard and touched him (see 1 John 1:1–4). God gave this great honor to a woman whose broken life had experienced healing (Luke 8:2). In Jewish culture, this was surprising. A woman could not even be a witness in court. No Jew at that time would make up such a story.

John 20:19

- the disciples were together with the doors locked: The disciples were afraid that they might be punished for following Jesus.
- Peace be with you!: This was a common Jewish greeting (see also 3 John 1:15). But Jesus was doing more than just greeting his disciples. He was offering the Messiah's peace and delivering the gift of his kingdom (see Isaiah 9:6; 52:7; see John 14:27; 16:33).

John 20:20

The reality that Jesus had been raised from the dead was quite clear. Jesus showed them the wounds from the nails and the spear. He did not fake death but conquered it. He was no ghost but a real man with a real body. He had been dead but was now alive. Jesus was fully human both in life (1:14) and in his resurrection.

John 20:21

I am sending you: God sent Jesus into the world to establish his kingdom. Now, Jesus is sending his disciples to continue his mission. Christ's messengers spread the truth of his words to the world (see 17:18).

John 20:22

Jesus commissioned his disciples and gave them the Holy Spirit. The Spirit had not yet been given earlier, because Jesus had not yet been glorified (7:39).

After his resurrection, the glorified Jesus gave the Spirit to his followers. This gift fulfilled many promises that the Spirit would be sent (14:16, 26; 15:26; 16:7, 13). It also points ahead to the Spirit's powerful coming at Pentecost (Acts 1:4–5; 2:1–47).

John 20:23

If you forgive anyone his sins: The work of Christ's followers continues the work of Christ. They do not give or take away God's forgiveness on their own. Instead, they act according to the guidance of Jesus through the Holy Spirit (15:5; 14:31).

John 20:24–25

Thomas: See also 11:16; 14:5. Thomas was not present when Jesus first appeared. He remained full of doubt even after his friends said they had seen the Lord. Thomas wanted the same direct experience they had.

John 20:26–27

- Eight days later was the first day of the Jewish week (Sunday). This was one week after the resurrection of Jesus. At that time, people included the current day when counting forward. The appearance of Jesus on this Sunday helps explain why the disciples met for worship on "the Lord's Day" (see Revelation 1:10).
- Peace be with you: This scene was just like the first appearance of Jesus (John 20:19–20). Jesus had already heard the complaint of Thomas, and now Jesus answered directly.

- believe: Jesus challenged Thomas to believe in the resurrection like the others did.

John 20:28

"My Lord and my God!": This was not a shout of surprise but a statement of deep faith. It completes John's declaration of Jesus's divinity that has framed the whole book (see 1:1–18).

John 20:29

Jesus speaks of the generations of Christians who, through the testimony of others, would believe without seeing.

John 20:30–31

Many scholars think these words are the end of John's Gospel and consider chapter 21 to be an addition. John's account is only a selection of the many miracles and signs Jesus performed.

John 20:31

so that you may believe: Some manuscripts use the present tense, showing that John wrote to encourage those who already believe. Other manuscripts read "that you may [come to] believe," which suggests that John was helping people begin to have faith (compare 1:7).

John 21:1–25

This final chapter includes a story about the resurrected Jesus in Galilee. It describes the conversation between Peter and Jesus about Peter's love for him (21:1–14; 21:15–23). The chapter concludes by summarizing the authority and importance of John's eyewitness account (21:24–25).

John 21:2

- Several of the disciples returned to fishing in the Sea of Galilee. This was not a sign that their faith had weakened. Even rabbis who regularly preached kept practicing their occupations (see Acts 18:3; 20:34; 1 Corinthians 4:12).
- The sons of Zebedee were James and John (see Matthew 4:21).

John 21:3

Fishing was usually successful in the early hours of the morning. However, this trip was useless and they caught nothing all night.

John 21:4

Jesus was standing on the shore, but the men did not recognize him (compare 20:11–16; Luke 24:13–53).

John 21:6

Cast the net on the right side: To throw a net into the sea at random would not be helpful. But when they followed the stranger's advice, they caught many fish immediately (21:11).

John 21:7

- "It is the Lord!": John recognized Jesus, likely remembering a similar miracle had happened before (Luke 5:1–11).
- Peter, who had taken off his clothes while working, put on his tunic (his outer clothing) to meet the Lord.

John 21:9

Cooked fish and bread were the main foods in the diet of those living in Galilee. Jesus offered the men breakfast. The charcoal fire reminds us of when Peter denied Jesus (18:18).

John 21:11

This miracle showed generous provision (similar to 2:1–12; 6:1–15). The number 153 does not have a symbolic meaning.

John 21:12–13

None of the disciples dared to ask Him, "Who are You?": Jesus looked different after God raised him from the dead. After his resurrection, Jesus was truly the same person. Yet his body was transformed and not limited in the same way. When he gave them bread and fish, their doubts disappeared (compare 6:11; Luke 24:30).

John 21:14

This scene on the beach was the third time Jesus had appeared (see 20:11–23, 26–29).

John 21:15

more than these? (Or more than these others do?): Jesus reminded Peter of his claim to be more faithful and brave than the others (13:37; Matthew 26:33; Mark 14:29). He was urging Peter to examine himself.

John 21:15–17

- Do you love me?: These three questions and affirmations recall Peter's three denials (18:15–18, 25–27).

Jesus invited Peter to reaffirm everything he had denied.
- The Greek word for love in the first two questions (agapaō) differs from the word in his third question (phileō). In each case, Peter responded with the second word (phileō). Most Greek scholars view the two words as synonyms in this situation.

The conversation Jesus had with Peter focused not on the quality of Peter's love, but rather on Peter's task to care for the followers of Jesus. First Peter 5:2–4 might be a meditation on these events.

John 21:17

Feed my sheep: Jesus, who knows everything, understood that despite Peter's terrible failure, he still had faith and commitment to Jesus (1:42; 2:25; 16:30). These words called Peter to care for and protect Christ's followers.

John 21:18

- You will stretch out your hands: Jesus was probably predicting Peter would likewise die on a cross. According to tradition, this is how Peter died.
- someone else will dress you (literally bind you): Jesus refers to capture, slavery, and crucifixion. They often tied victims to the cross.

John 21:19

- The rest of Peter's life was a ministry tending the flock of God, and his martyrdom was a kind of death that glorifies God.
- Follow me: This might require suffering and death (see 13:16; 15:18–21).

John 21:20–22

"Lord, what about him?": Peter wanted to know if John would also face death for his faith. Jesus said it was not Peter's concern to know how or when John would die. Peter's job was to follow Jesus, just as John already was.

This event shows John's idea of being a disciple: What matters most for the disciple of Jesus is to follow him and do his will, no matter what happens.

John 21:23

What Jesus said to Peter spread, causing some to conclude that John would not die until Jesus returned in his second coming. What Jesus said when he rebuked Peter (21:22) is repeated to answer that rumor. Those among the community of believers who believed this rumor were thus instructed to abandon any guessing about what would happen to John. According to tradition, John died peacefully in Ephesus at an old age, surrounded by fellow believers.

John 21:24

- This is the disciple who testifies to these things and who has written them down: John's Gospel is based on his personal experiences. It is not a story written from rumors or guesses, but from the memories of a man who spent important years with Jesus. He remembered, with the help of the Holy Spirit, what Jesus said and did (14:26).
- we know: This account of the life of Christ was not a guess or from weak memories. Instead, John based it on the confident knowledge of reliable eyewitness accounts.

John 21:25

not even the world itself would have space for the books: John ends his Gospel acknowledging that the story he has described is larger than anything he can imagine or fully communicate. Even though it is wonderful for us to experience, it does not show the full glory of the person he describes. John wants us to know that there is always more to Christ than we can understand.